

TRANSCENDENCE COREBOOK

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INTRODUCTION

The physical world does not end where the senses stop responding.

The Limbo exists in parallel to material reality, but it does not appear as a visible layer or as a place an ordinary creature can look into. Most beings live without perceiving it. They only know its effects when the separation between dimensions gives way enough for that pressure to reach the world.

A filtration does not always announce itself through violence. Sometimes it alters a simple relationship between body and environment: sound arrives late, light no longer orders distance correctly, or the ground answers weight with a resistance its shape does not explain. What changes is not only how things appear, but how they behave.

This kind of alteration is called extranatural influence. It is not defined by intensity, but by origin: pressure from the Limbo acting upon perceptible reality.

WHAT IS TRANSCENDENCE

Transcendence is a tabletop roleplaying game for one Narrator and two to five players. Its sessions take place in a world where reality can hold, give way, or deform under extranatural pressure.

Characters investigate, travel, fight, endure, and recover in scenes where position and timing carry weight. A bad decision does not disappear at the end of a turn. It can leave a wound, exhaust the body, close a route, or change the state of the scene.

The system does not treat combat as a sequence of closed rounds. Each creature acts within an active timeline, and every action moves its next opportunity to intervene. Acting earlier can create an immediate advantage. It can also leave less room to respond later.

Progression carries characters from Novice to Transcendent. That growth is not only a matter of increasing values. It defines what a character can sustain, what they learn to do under pressure, and what risks they can take when the world stops behaving in a stable way.

Horror does not appear as decoration. It enters the scene when the Limbo alters bodies, places, senses, or conditions. When that pressure has consequences, it stops being atmosphere and becomes a rule.

WHAT YOU NEED

Each player needs a character sheet and a complete dice set. The Narrator may need additional dice for effects, adversaries, or hidden rolls.

No map or miniatures are required. Transcendence can be played through verbal description, as long as the table maintains clarity around position, distance, and the current state of the scene.

If the group prefers visual support, it can use maps, markers, tokens, or any spatial reference that helps track conflict. The tool does not matter. Position does.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This book is organized to be read in order during a first reading. The opening chapters present the foundation of the system. Later chapters develop character creation, progression, conflict, equipment, horror, adversaries, and setting.

After the first reading, the book also works as a reference. The general rules explain how actions are resolved. Later chapters expand those rules for specific situations.

CHAPTER	CONTENTS
3	General rules and rolling system
4	Skills and proficiencies
5	Character creation
6	Species
7	Backgrounds and origins
8	Conflict and combat
9	Techniques
10	Equipment and resources
11	Cosmic horror and corruption
12	Narrator toolkit and environmental conditions
13	Adversaries and bestiary
14	Setting and factions
15	Scenarios and adventures
16	Appendices
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GENERAL RULES

DICE

Transcendence mainly uses ten-sided dice. Some mechanics, especially weapon damage, use other die sizes: d4, d6, d8, and d12. Certain Narrator rolls may use d100, resolved with two d10s read as tens and ones.

Each player needs a character sheet to track values, resources, and active effects. The table may also use tokens, markers, or visual references to represent positions on the **ATB** timeline.

SPECIFIC RULES OVER GENERAL RULES

When a specific rule contradicts a general rule, the specific rule takes precedence. A particular mechanic always has priority over the background rule that would normally resolve that situation.

Example: if an ability defines its duration as $\text{Level} \div 2$ rounded down, that definition replaces the general rule for rounding up.

THE NARRATOR AND THE RULES

The Narrator applies the rules to resolve actions, consequences, and the state of the scene. When a situation is not covered directly, the Narrator uses the closest mechanic and builds the result from there.

A specific rule provides the most precise framework for resolving its situation. Changing it should be an exception, not a habit, and the decision must remain consistent with the world, the scene, and the information available to the players.

ROUNDING

When a calculation produces a fraction or decimal, round up to the nearest whole number, unless a specific rule says otherwise. This rule applies to damage, durations, ratings, and any other numeric value in the system.

STRONGEST CONDITION

When a creature receives multiple effects of the same type, only the most significant one applies. This includes penalties, bonuses, movement reductions, and other modifiers that affect the same value or state.

To compare effects of the same type, check magnitude first. If both effects have the same magnitude, the one with the longer remaining duration takes precedence. If the new effect surpasses the existing one, it replaces it and its duration begins from that moment.

Example: a character suffers a penalty that halves movement speed for 3 turns. Later, they receive another penalty of the same type lasting 6 turns. Because the magnitude is the same, the longer duration remains: the penalty stays active for 6 turns from the new effect.

ADVENTURE CYCLE

The game is organized around three phases: **Exploration**, **Conflict**, and **Interlude**. Each phase indicates what kind of pressure dominates the scene, how time is handled, and which rules move to the front.

These phases are not turns or mandatory structures. The table uses them to recognize what is at stake and which part of the system should resolve the situation.

EXPLORATION

Exploration covers movement through the world, investigation, resource gathering, and interaction with places or inhabitants. There is no immediate tactical urgency, but decisions leave a trace: a chosen route, an ignored clue, an opened door, a spent resource.

During this phase, rules for rest, specialization, preparation, and environmental management operate with greater freedom.

CONFLICT

Conflict begins when a scene demands immediate tactical resolution. This may be combat, a dangerous confrontation, a chase, a desperate defense, or an obstacle that cannot be resolved without measuring time, position, and consequence.

During Conflict, the **ATB** system takes control of time. The rules for **Desgaste**, actions, and reactions determine what each creature can do and how much it costs to intervene.

Every participant in a Conflict is a **creature**. This term includes player characters, Narrator characters, adversaries, and any entity acting within the scene. The full flow of Conflict is described in the Combat chapter.

INTERLUDE

Interlude covers extended periods outside detailed scene-by-scene play. Characters craft, repair, rest, treat wounds, manage resources, develop relationships, or prepare for the next advance.

Time moves with less immediate pressure, but consequences tend to last longer. What is decided during an Interlude can define which resources, wounds, bonds, or risks shape the next scene.

EXAMPLE

A group moves through ruins in search of a relic. While they explore corridors, study traces, and decide which route to follow, the scene is in Exploration.

When a creature emerges from the depths of the sanctuary and forces immediate action under pressure, the scene shifts into Conflict. Time stops moving freely, and the **ATB** system determines the order of intervention.

After the encounter, the characters patch equipment, treat wounds, and organize the next advance. The scene enters Interlude.

ROLLING SYSTEM AND COMPETENCIES

RESOLVING A ROLL

Rolls resolve actions when the outcome is not assured and a relevant consequence exists. They can appear in combat, exploration, social interaction, or any scene where pressure makes failure matter.

The base of a roll is a **d10**. Characteristics, competencies, equipment, traits, conditions, and other modifiers are added according to the type of action.

Player characters can risk certain rolls through **Evolutionary Advantage**. NPCs and other creatures use a more direct layer, based on Traits, special capabilities, and the function they serve within the scene.

Not every trained roll uses Evolutionary Advantage. Some rolls, such as Resistance Rolls, represent internal responses of the body, mind, or essence of the character and are resolved directly.

EVOLUTIONARY ADVANTAGE

Evolutionary Advantage represents how a character approaches a trained action under pressure. Before rolling, the player chooses whether to prioritize immediate execution or the possibility of learning.

This choice only applies to rolls where the character has active control over execution:

- **Attack Roll**
- **Defense Roll**
- **Specialization Roll**

It does not apply to:

- **Resistance Roll**
- **Characteristic Roll**

- **Personality Trait Roll**

Resistances can progress, but not through Evolutionary Advantage. They progress through exposure, survival, and adaptation.

EXECUTION ADVANTAGE

The player rolls two dice and uses the higher result to resolve the roll.

The action is more likely to succeed, but it cannot generate progress. The character focuses on execution, not on exposing themselves to the kind of error that teaches.

LEARNING ADVANTAGE

The player rolls two dice and uses the lower result to resolve the roll. The higher die is reserved as the learning die.

After the action is resolved, compare the learning die against the die used for the roll and the rank of the competency that can progress.

$$\text{Learning die} > \text{die used} + \text{competency rank}$$

If the learning die exceeds that sum, the character marks 1 progress point in the corresponding competency, provided the action meets the progression conditions for its type.

A roll can fail and still teach. It can also succeed without generating progress. The competency that progresses depends on the type of action and what happened in the scene.

NPCs AND OTHER CREATURES

NPCs, adversaries, and Narrator-controlled creatures do not follow the same progression rules as player characters. They do not choose Evolutionary Advantage or accumulate competency progress during play.

Instead, they use **Traits**: advantages, disadvantages, resistances, special capabilities, or behaviors tied to their nature, environment, emotional state, or combat role.

TYPES OF ROLLS

The formulas in this chapter use characteristics such as Agility, Strength, Tenacity, Composure, and Resilience. These values are assigned during character creation. Here, they appear only as parts of each roll.

ATTACK ROLL (A.R.)

The Attack Roll measures whether an offensive action connects. It can come from a weapon, maneuver, skill, or object used under pressure. It is compared against defense, resistance, or another opposed roll when appropriate.

Formula:

```
A.R. = 1d10 + competency level + competency rank + associated  
characteristic + additional bonuses
```

The competency level adds accumulated practice. The competency rank represents the degree of mastery reached. The associated characteristic adds the physical, mental, or sensory aptitude that supports execution.

DEFENSE ROLL (D.R.)

The Defense Roll measures whether a creature avoids an incoming attack. It combines reflexes, mobility, evasive training, armor in the threatened zone, and additional protection from shields or other defensive effects.

Formula:

```
D.R. = 1d10 + applicable Evasion + applicable Agility + defensive bonuses
```

Applicable Evasion includes the Evasion level and Evasion rank that can be used according to the armor protecting the resolved hit zone.

```
Applicable Evasion = applicable Evasion level + applicable Evasion rank
```

Both Evasion and Agility depend on the armor type protecting the resolved hit zone:

ARMOR IN THE ZONE	APPLICABLE EVASION	APPLICABLE AGILITY
Unarmored	Full Evasion	Full Agility
Light	Full Evasion	Full Agility
Medium	Full Evasion	Half Agility, minimum 1
Heavy	Half Evasion, minimum 1	0

For medium armor, calculate half Agility and round up, unless a specific rule says otherwise.

For heavy armor, calculate half Evasion and round up, unless a specific rule says otherwise.

A shield contributes a general bonus to D.R. as part of defensive equipment. Its competency does not progress through this generic roll; it progresses through shield Techniques and maneuvers.

D.R. must match or exceed the opponent's offensive roll to avoid damage or additional effects. If it fails, armor in the resolved zone may still absorb part of the impact. Full details for zones, pieces, and block are described in the Equipment chapter.

IMPACT ROLL (I.R.)

The Impact Roll is resolved after an attack beats defense or the corresponding opposed roll. It defines how much damage reaches the target.

I.R. does not use a base d10. It uses the weapon's damage die, multiplied by the character's competency rank with that weapon. The associated characteristic and weapon grade add execution and equipment power.

Formula:

$$\text{I.R.} = (\text{competency rank} \times \text{weapon damage}) + (\text{associated characteristic} \times \text{weapon grade})$$

Weapon Damage

The weapon's base damage uses the die indicated by its category: d4, d6, d8, d10, or d12.

If a character has rank 3 with a weapon that deals d8 damage, they roll 3d8 as the base impact before adding the associated characteristic by weapon grade.

Impact with Untrained Weapons

A character can attack with a weapon they have no competency with. The strike can connect, but impact is reduced.

Formula:

$$\text{Untrained I.R.} = ((1 \times \text{weapon damage}) + (\text{associated characteristic} \times \text{weapon grade})) / 2$$

This formula keeps the weapon usable, but limits how much an untrained character can draw from it.

CHARACTERISTIC ROLL (C.R.)

The Characteristic Roll is used when an action depends on a general aptitude: Strength, Agility, Tenacity, Wisdom, or any other relevant characteristic.

It does not use specific training. It takes the character's aptitude and applies it to a concrete situation.

Formula:

$$\text{C.R.} = 1d10 + \text{characteristic} + \text{Reference Level} + \text{additional bonuses}$$

C.R. is used when no specific competency resolves the action better. It does not generate progress by itself.

RESISTANCE ROLL (R.R.)

The Resistance Roll resolves whether a creature withstands, avoids, or reduces a harmful effect: poison, infection, affliction, curse, or alteration.

Unlike an Attack Roll, Defense Roll, or Specialization Roll, an R.R. does not represent voluntary execution by the character. It represents a response of the body, mind, or essence against a danger trying to affect it.

For that reason, an R.R. is resolved with a single die and does not use Evolutionary Advantage by default.

The base characteristic depends on the effect type. The corresponding resistance adds accumulated experience against that danger.

Formulas:

EFFECT	FORMULA
Poisons or infections	$1d10 + \text{Tenacity} + \text{corresponding resistance} + \text{additional bonuses}$
Afflictions or curses	$1d10 + \text{Composure} + \text{corresponding resistance} + \text{additional bonuses}$
Alterations	$1d10 + \text{Resilience} + \text{corresponding resistance} + \text{additional bonuses}$

The goal is to match or exceed the effect's difficulty to avoid, mitigate, or reduce its consequences.

An R.R. does not generate progress through Learning Advantage. Resistances progress through exposure, as described in the Resistances section.

A specific rule, Technique, Grievance, or exceptional effect can alter this structure, but it must say so explicitly.

SPECIALIZATION ROLL (S.R.)

The Specialization Roll is used for trained skills: climbing, swimming, disarming traps, escaping restraints, or any practiced domain defined as a specialization.

Formula:

$$\text{S.R.} = 1d10 + \text{specialization competency level} + \text{competency rank} + \text{associated characteristic} + \text{additional bonuses}$$

The level adds accumulated practice. The rank adds the degree of mastery reached in that specialization.

PERSONALITY TRAIT ROLL (P.R.)

During exploration or conflict, a player may propose that one of their Personality Traits influences the situation. If the Narrator accepts the justification, the character can make a Personality Trait Roll instead of a Characteristic Roll or Specialization Roll.

Formula:

$$\text{P.R.} = 2d10$$

This roll does not depend on competencies and does not generate progress. It depends on the invoked trait, its weight in the scene, and the Narrator’s approval.

DIFFICULTY THRESHOLDS

Every roll is compared against a number. That number may come from another participant’s roll or from a fixed threshold established by the system or the Narrator.

When the challenge comes from an active opponent, both parties roll and compare results directly. When it comes from the environment, the complexity of a task, or another system, the Narrator sets a threshold using one of five difficulty tiers.

$$\text{Threshold} = \text{base} + \text{RL}$$

Base is the fixed value of the chosen difficulty tier. **RL** is the Reference Level of the context: the RL of the creature or entity posing the challenge, or the equivalent the Narrator assigns to the environment, obstacle, or task.

TIER	BASE	FORMULA
Fundamental	5	5 + RL
Challenging	8	8 + RL
Rigorous	11	11 + RL
Demanding	14	14 + RL
Extreme	17	17 + RL

These five tiers apply to all systems that require beating a fixed threshold: S.R., C.R., R.R., crafting, Grievances, and equivalent tests.

The Narrator announces the difficulty tier before requesting the roll, unless revealing that information contradicts the nature of the scene.

If an A.R., D.R., or S.R. can generate progress through Learning Advantage, the player must know the threshold before choosing how to roll.

R.R. does not use Learning Advantage. If a Resistance can progress, it does so through exposure after the effect is resolved.

COMPETENCIES

Competencies indicate what a character has practiced and how far that practice has gone. Some belong to combat. Others belong to survival, knowledge, crafts, movement, or concrete skills.

Competencies fulfill two functions:

- modify rolls
- allow progression when the character faces relevant situations

Not all competencies progress in the same way.

COMPETENCY TYPE	HOW IT PROGRESSES
Weapons, Evasion, and Specializations	Through Learning Advantage
Armor	By absorbing damage after a failed D.R.
Shields	Through shield Techniques and maneuvers
Resistances	Through exposure, consequence, and survival

Competencies do not replace characteristics. Characteristics provide the base. Competencies show how much the character has trained, practiced, refined, or adapted that base.

COMPETENCY LEVELS AND RANKS

Each competency has a level and a rank.

- **Competency level** records accumulated numeric progress.
- **Competency rank** summarizes the degree of mastery reached.

RANK	NAME	LEVELS
0	Untrained	0
1	Novice	1–2
2	Adept	3–4
3	Expert	5–6
4	Master	7–8
5	Consummate	9–10
6	Transcendent	11+

A new rank is reached every 2 competency levels. Specializations grant Synapsis when entering each new rank, as described in the Specializations chapter.

STARTING COMPETENCIES

The character's background determines which competencies begin trained. Competencies granted by background start at level 1, equivalent to Novice rank.

All other competencies begin at level 0. The character is considered Untrained in them.

COMPETENCY PROGRESSION

Competencies increase when the character faces a situation that demands something real for their current rank and meets the progression conditions of that competency.

To gain one competency level, the following are required:

- 5 progress points in major-affinity specializations
- 10 progress points in all other competencies

A specialization's affinity is defined in the Specializations chapter.

Resistances do not use major affinity by base rule, unless a specific rule says otherwise.

APPROPRIATE TESTS FOR PROGRESSION

Not every action teaches. For progress to occur, the situation must demand something real for the character's current rank.

Martial Competencies

Martial competencies progress when the character faces appropriately difficult adversaries and puts their training into practice.

In the case of weapons, the character must use Learning Advantage, attack, hit, and deal effective damage to a creature whose level is at least equal to the character's RL -1.

Evasion, Armor, and Shield

These competencies progress when the character is exposed to relevant threats and responds in a way that leaves learning behind: avoiding, absorbing, or intervening through a defensive technique.

- Evasion progresses with a successful D.R. under Learning Advantage.
- Armor progresses when a D.R. fails and armor absorbs part of the impact.
- Shield progresses through successful shield Techniques or maneuvers.

Resistances

Resistances progress when the character is exposed to a real danger, suffers its consequences, and survives.

They do not progress through Evolutionary Advantage.

Specialization Competencies

Specializations only progress when test difficulty is coherent with the character's rank.

CURRENT RANK	CAN PROGRESS WITH TESTS OF...
Novice	Any tier
Adept	Fundamental or higher
Expert	Challenging or higher
Master	Rigorous or higher
Consummate	Demanding or higher
Transcendent	Extreme

COMPETENCY TYPES AND THEIR EFFECTS

WEAPONS

Weapon competency measures mastery of a specific weapon type.

Bonuses

- Each weapon competency level grants **+1** to A.R.
- Each competency rank grants an additional **+1** to A.R.
- Each competency rank adds one damage die to I.R.

Progression

Weapon competency increases when the character uses Learning Advantage, hits with that weapon or object, and deals effective damage in a relevant encounter.

ARMOR

Armor competency covers efficient use of defensive pieces. It is split by type: light, medium, and heavy.

Bonuses

- Each competency level increases the block of armor of that type by **1** when that piece resolves the impact in its zone.

Progression

Armor competency increases on a failed D.R., provided the impact resolves in a protected zone and the armor actually absorbs part of the damage.

The character does not choose Learning Advantage to progress armor. Armor teaches when it receives real pressure and absorbs part of the impact.

Progress applies to the armor type protecting that zone.

SHIELDS

Shield competency measures technical mastery of shield use in combat.

Bonuses

- Each competency rank grants access to additional Techniques according to shield type.
- Reaching Master reduces the movement penalty of the equipped shield by **grade**, minimum **0**.

Progression

Shield competency increases when the character uses shield Techniques or maneuvers successfully. It does not progress through generic D.R.

EVASION

Evasion competency measures the character's skill at anticipating and avoiding attacks.

Bonuses

- Each competency level grants **+1** to Evasion.
- Each competency rank grants an additional **+1** to Evasion.
- Evasion is added to D.R. according to the armor type protecting the resolved hit zone.

Progression

Evasion increases on a successful D.R. with Learning Advantage, provided the character avoids a relevant attack or threat through mobility, anticipation, or reflexes.

SPECIALIZATION

Competency in a specialization measures technical mastery of a concrete skill.

Bonuses

- Each competency level grants **+1** to S.R.
- Each competency rank grants an additional **+1** to S.R.

Progression

Specialization increases by overcoming tests appropriate to the character's current rank and meeting the learning condition of Evolutionary Advantage.

RESISTANCES

Resistances cover specific dangers that poison, infect, alter, afflict, or curse a creature. They are not trained only through controlled repetition. They often grow through exposure, survival, and adaptation.

Resistances do not reduce Impact, elemental damage, or Wounds. Damage is resolved through the relationship between Impact, Block, and the Wound or HP rules. If a fire, water, light, or other elemental-origin attack deals damage, that damage follows the normal flow unless a specific rule says otherwise.

Resistances are added to the corresponding R.R., but they do not use Evolutionary Advantage.

Poison

Bonus

- Each competency level grants **+1** to R.R. against poisons.
-

Infection

Bonus

- Each competency level grants **+1** to R.R. against infections.
-

Affliction

Bonus

- Each competency level grants **+1** to R.R. against afflictions.
 - Each competency rank grants **+1** to Affliction R.R. made during meditation.
-

Alteration

Bonus

- Each competency level grants **+1** to R.R. against alterations.
-

Curses

Bonus

- Each competency level grants **+1** to rolls made to detect or resist curses.
-

LEARNING THROUGH EXPOSURE

Resistances increase when the character is exposed to a real danger, suffers it, and survives its consequences.

A Resistance can gain progress if all of the following conditions are met:

- the character makes an R.R. against the corresponding danger
- the danger is relevant for the character's current rank
- the character fails the R.R. or suffers a partial consequence from the effect
- the character survives the exposure

If these conditions are met, the character marks **1** progress point in the corresponding Resistance.

Completely resisting a danger does not generate progress by base rule. Resistance improves when the character is forced to adapt, not when they avoid all consequence.

The Narrator can deny progress if the exposure is trivial, controlled without real risk, repeated artificially, or insufficient to challenge the character's current rank.

A specific rule, Technique, Grievance, treatment, mutation, or special condition can modify this learning.

About Elemental Resistance

Elemental Resistance and **Elemental Vulnerability** are not competencies. They do not progress through Evolutionary Advantage and are not part of the character's trainable resistance competencies.

When a creature, material, object, Technique, or effect has resistance or vulnerability against an elemental origin, it is resolved through the rules for **Elemental Damage and Affinities**.

REFERENCE LEVEL

The **Reference Level (RL)** summarizes a character's overall competency. It is not chosen or assigned directly. It comes from the set of competencies the character has developed.

CHARACTER RL

A character's RL is calculated as the average, rounded up, of all their base competencies.

$$RL_c = \lceil \text{average of all the character's base competencies} \rceil$$

All competencies listed on the character sheet with a numeric value are included. Competencies marked as  are not included in the calculation.

GROUP RL

When the encounter involves multiple player characters, the group's RL is calculated as the average, rounded up, of the individual RL values of all active PCs in the encounter.

$$RL_g = \lceil \text{average of the } RL_c \text{ of all active PCs in the encounter} \rceil$$

The Narrator uses group RL to scale creatures, set base difficulties, and compare forces between sides without reviewing every individual competency.

UPDATING RL

A character's RL may be revised when:

- the character gains new competencies
- several relevant competencies increase in rank
- a new arc or episode begins

It does not need to be recalculated every session.

RL IN THE CHARACTERISTIC ROLL

RL enters directly into the Characteristic Roll. As the character becomes more broadly competent, they respond better even when the action does not depend on specific training.

RL does not replace a trained competency. It prevents the character's overall experience from disappearing in basic tests.

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN ROLLS AND COMPETENCIES

ROLL	COMPETENCY USED	PROGRESSION
A.R.	Competency of the weapon or object used	If it uses Learning Advantage, succeeds, and deals effective damage, the weapon or object used progresses.
D.R.	Applicable Evasion according to armor	If it uses Learning Advantage and succeeds, Evasion progresses. If it fails and armor absorbs impact, the armor type of the resolved zone progresses.
I.R.	Weapon competency rank	Does not progress by itself.
C.R.	None by default	Does not progress by itself.
R.R.	Resistance corresponding to the effect type	Does not use Evolutionary Advantage. If the character fails or suffers a partial consequence and survives a relevant danger, the corresponding Resistance progresses.
S.R.	Competency of the specialization involved	If it uses Learning Advantage, succeeds, and the difficulty is appropriate, the specialization used progresses.
P.R.	None	Does not progress by itself.

Shield competency progresses separately, through successful shield Techniques and maneuvers.

EXAMPLE

A character tries to evade the strike of a heavy creature while using Learning Advantage. They roll two dice and resolve the D.R. with the lower die. The higher die is reserved as the learning die.

If the character avoids the attack and the learning die exceeds the progress condition, the situation can generate progress in Evasion.

If the D.R. fails, but the armor in the resolved zone absorbs part of the impact, the situation can generate progress in the corresponding armor type.

Later, the same character suffers a toxin and makes a Poison R.R. This roll is resolved with a single d10; it does not use Evolutionary Advantage.

If the character fails the R.R., suffers the effect, and survives, they can mark 1 progress in Poison Resistance, provided the exposure is relevant for their current rank.

The competency that progresses depends on the result of the scene, not only on the type of roll.

SPECIALIZATIONS

Specializations are trainable domains. They represent practices the character has developed: actions, trades, knowledge, or disciplines that can be attempted, failed, and refined over time.

A characteristic measures a base aptitude. A specialization measures what the character has practiced with that aptitude.

In play, specializations serve three functions:

- modify Specialization Rolls
 - allow progression through Learning Advantage
 - activate Synapsis when new ranks are reached
-

WHAT THEY REPRESENT

A specialization is not a power the character simply possesses. It is a practice.

Two characters with the same characteristic can act in different ways if they have trained different domains. A character with high Wisdom and Medicine interprets wounds, symptoms, and treatments. Another with high Wisdom and Survival reads tracks, weather, routes, and signs in the environment.

The characteristic gives the base. The specialization defines how that base becomes action.

STARTING SPECIALIZATIONS

During character creation, every character begins with four starting specializations:

SOURCE	AMOUNT	STARTING LEVEL	STARTING RANK
Background	3	1	Novice
Universal Tenacity choice	1	1	Novice

The universal Tenacity specialization must be one of the following:

- **March**
- **Acclimation**
- **Tolerance**

The same specialization cannot be chosen twice during character creation.

All specializations not chosen begin at level **0**, rank **Untrained**.

Starting specializations already grant the Synopsis corresponding to Novice rank during character creation.

CATEGORIES

Specializations are grouped into five categories. The category indicates what kind of domain the specialization represents; it does not determine which characteristic it uses by itself.

CATEGORY	TYPE OF DOMAIN
Physical	Bodily technique, movement, effort, and practiced physical control
Mental	Interpretation, cunning, attention, situational reading, and adaptive reasoning
Social	Influence, expression, projection, deception, and interpersonal control
Arts and Crafts	Practical trades and concrete artistic disciplines, such as music, dance, juggling, puppetry, or stage performance
Knowledge	Formal study, academic interpretation, structured knowledge, and technical understanding

A Physical specialization may be linked to Strength, Agility, or Tenacity depending on what it covers. A Social specialization may be linked to Cunning, Composure, Aura, or Presence.

The category organizes the domain. The characteristic determines which value is added to the roll.

The complete list of specializations, their associated characteristics, and their common uses appears in the **Specialization Catalog**, located in the appendices.

SPECIALIZATION ROLL

When a character acts through a specialization, they make a **Specialization Roll (S.R.)**.

S.R. = 1d10 + competency level + competency rank + associated characteristic + additional bonuses

COMPONENT	WHAT IT REPRESENTS
Competency level	Numeric progress reached in that specialization
Competency rank	Current degree of mastery
Associated characteristic	Characteristic linked to the specialization used
Additional bonuses	Situational modifiers, equipment, active Techniques, or other applicable effects

Use an S.R. when the action depends on a concrete practice: climbing, swimming, tracking, healing, persuading, crafting, disarming traps, interpreting symbols, or any other domain defined as a specialization.

UNTRAINED

Any character can attempt a roll in a specialization they do not have trained.

An **Untrained** character uses only the die and the associated characteristic.

Untrained S.R. = 1d10 + associated characteristic

Level and rank are 0.

Lack of training does not prevent the attempt. It limits what the character can reach. An advanced test may exist in the fiction, but remain outside the mechanical reach of someone without practice.

Developing a specialization does not enable the action. It makes it sustainable.

LEVELS AND RANKS

Each specialization has a level and a rank.

RANK	NAME	LEVELS
0	Untrained	0
1	Novice	1–2
2	Adept	3–4
3	Expert	5–6
4	Master	7–8
5	Consummate	9–10
6	Transcendent	11+

The level measures numeric advancement. The rank summarizes the degree of mastery reached.

Each new rank can unlock new possibilities, activate Synopsis, and serve as a requirement for Techniques.

PROGRESSION

Specializations progress through use under pressure.

For an S.R. to generate progress, three conditions must be met:

- the character uses **Learning Advantage**
- the test difficulty is appropriate for their current rank
- the learning die exceeds the progress condition

Learning die > die used + competency rank

If these conditions are met, the character marks 1 progress point in that specialization.

Progress does not appear only because the player chooses to learn. The action must demand something real, and the declared specialization must match what the character is doing.

PROGRESS REQUIRED PER LEVEL

The amount of progress required depends on the character's affinity.

AFFINITY	PROGRESS REQUIRED TO GAIN 1 LEVEL
No major affinity	10 points
Major affinity	5 points

Major affinity comes from the character's background.

A character with a martial background may have major affinity in Physical specializations. A character with an artisan background may have it in Arts and Crafts.

Major affinity does not block other specializations. It only reduces the cost of progressing in those that belong to that category.

APPROPRIATE TESTS FOR PROGRESSION

Not every action teaches. For a specialization to progress, the difficulty must be coherent with the character's current rank.

CURRENT RANK	CAN PROGRESS WITH TESTS OF...
Novice	Any tier
Adept	Fundamental or higher
Expert	Challenging or higher
Master	Rigorous or higher
Consummate	Demanding or higher
Transcendent	Extreme

A test that is too simple does not generate progress for someone who already dominates that kind of action.

NARRATOR VALIDATION

The Narrator validates whether the declared specialization matches the real action.

The player must explain how they use that specialization in the scene. If the justification does not match the declared domain, the roll may be resolved with another specialization, with a Characteristic Roll, or without the possibility of progress.

A character cannot use Traps to analyze a creature's behavior only because the player wants to progress Traps. There must be a concrete relationship between the action and the domain used.

The practiced domain must reflect the real action.

SYNOPSIS

Synopsis represents the way practice modifies the character.

Each specialization is associated with a characteristic. When the specialization reaches a new rank, the character gains a permanent +1 to that characteristic.

RANK	NAME	SYNOPSIS ON ENTRY
0	Untrained	—
1	Novice	+1 to characteristic
2	Adept	+1 to characteristic
3	Expert	+1 to characteristic
4	Master	+1 to characteristic
5	Consummate	+1 to characteristic
6	Transcendent	+1 to characteristic

Synopsis applies when entering a new rank, not each time a level is gained.

During character creation, starting specializations begin at Novice rank. For that reason, each one immediately grants +1 to its associated characteristic.

BROAD OR DEEP GROWTH

A player can develop many specializations or concentrate on only a few.

Developing many specializations can activate Synopsis across several characteristics and widen the character's options.

Deepening a single specialization increases its S.R. bonuses and can grant access to more advanced Techniques.

Neither path is superior by default. Each one prioritizes a different form of growth.

DIRECT USE AND TECHNIQUES

Using a specialization produces a narrative result within the scene.

The character may observe, interpret, build, repair, persuade, remember, move, or act according to the domain used. That use can open information, routes, narrative advantages, or new possible actions.

By itself, direct use of a specialization does not automatically change the mechanical state of the scene, unless a rule, consequence, or Narrator decision says so.

A **Technique** is different. It is a specific application the character unlocks by reaching a certain competency level in one or more specializations.

Unlike direct use, a Technique produces a defined mechanical consequence when activated.

This distinction is structural:

USE	RESULT
Direct specialization use	Opens narrative or practical possibilities
Technique	Produces a defined mechanical consequence

QUICK SUMMARY

ELEMENT	RULE
Starting specialization	Level 1 / Novice rank
Untrained	Level 0 / rank 0
Trained S.R.	$1d10 + \text{level} + \text{rank} + \text{characteristic} + \text{bonuses}$
Untrained S.R.	$1d10 + \text{characteristic}$
Progress with major affinity	5 points per level
Progress without major affinity	10 points per level
Synapsis	+1 to characteristic when entering each new rank
Technique	Requires a specific domain and produces a defined mechanical consequence

EXAMPLE

A character uses Survival to read broken tracks at the edge of a flooded road.

The roll may reveal where a group passed, which route remains viable, and which signs in the terrain should be avoided. That result opens information and options.

By itself, that use does not damage an enemy, change initiative, or impose a mechanical condition.

If the character later unlocks a Technique tied to tracking or field reading, that Technique can add a defined mechanical consequence to the same kind of trained action.

CHARACTER CREATION

Character creation defines who you are at the start of the adventure, where you come from, and what capabilities you have developed before entering play.

To create a character, follow these steps in order:

1. Define the concept.
2. Record base characteristics.
3. Choose species.
4. Choose background.
5. Select starting specializations.
6. Apply Synopsis.
7. Calculate derived attributes.
8. Choose Personality Traits.
9. Record additional species attributes.

The order matters. Some steps modify values used later.

1. DEFINE THE CONCEPT

Before choosing numbers, define a brief idea of the character.

You do not need to write a full backstory. Answer three questions:

QUESTION	EXPECTED ANSWER
What kind of person or creature are they?	Their general identity
What drives them?	Their main motivation
How do they face the world?	Their attitude toward danger, conflict, other characters, or uncertainty

A concept should not be only a mechanical function.

Do not write only:

- “a strong character”
- “someone stealthy”
- “an intelligent character”

Frame the character as a concrete person:

- a patient hunter who learned to survive alone
- an old custodian who fears forgetting what they swore to protect
- an insecure noble trying to keep authority in a world that no longer respects it
- a fighter raised to endure pain before understanding it

Use this concept as a guide when choosing species, background, specializations, and Personality Traits.

At the end of this step, write a short concept phrase on your sheet.

2. RECORD BASE CHARACTERISTICS

All characteristics begin at 0.

This value does not mean the character is incompetent. It is a neutral baseline. Species and Synapsis will increase these values during character creation.

GROUP	CHARACTERISTIC	WHAT IT REPRESENTS
Physical	Strength	Physical power, pushing, carrying, striking, and raw exertion
Physical	Agility	Coordination, mobility, balance, and bodily reaction
Physical	Tenacity	Physical endurance, pain tolerance, fatigue, and prolonged strain
Mental	Intellect	Reasoning, memory, study, and formal understanding
Mental	Cunning	Improvisation, deception, practical creativity, and reading opportunities
Mental	Wisdom	Perception, intuition, judgment, and applied experience
Social	Composure	Self-control, emotional stability, and calm under pressure
Social	Aura	Natural and involuntary impression projected by the character
Social	Presence	Active projection, authority, influence, and social impact

At the end of this step, your sheet should have every characteristic at 0.

3. CHOOSE SPECIES

Species defines the character's biological and cultural foundation.

When you choose species, record everything indicated in its profile.

ELEMENT	WHAT TO RECORD
Longevity	Typical lifespan
Size	Size category
Height and weight	Physical reference range
Languages	Languages known at the start
Speed	Distance covered with a movement action
Characteristic bonuses	Starting increases granted by species
Other equivalent starting values	Competencies, senses, innate traits, or other special values
Heritage	Vulnerability, limitation, or ancestral mark
Legacy	Innate advantages or shared adaptations
Bodily attacks or natural weapons	Claws, fangs, horns, tail, pincers, stingers, or other natural combat forms
Variant	Internal adaptation of the species, if one exists

APPLY SPECIES BONUSES

After choosing species, increase the characteristics indicated by its profile.

$$\text{Current characteristic} = 0 + \text{species bonus}$$

The complete description of each species appears in the **Species** chapter.

At the end of this step, your sheet should have:

- chosen species
- species attributes recorded
- characteristic bonuses applied

4. CHOOSE BACKGROUND

Background represents the character's life before the adventure.

Each background grants two things:

BENEFIT	FUNCTION
Major affinity	Reduces required progress in one specialization category
Starting specializations	Defines three practices the character already developed before play

A specialization with major affinity needs

5

 progress points to gain a level.

All other specializations need

10

 progress points.

AVAILABLE BACKGROUNDS

MARTIAL ARTIST

The Martial Artist has devoted their life to bodily refinement, combat, or physical endurance.

TRAIT	VALUE
Major affinity	Physical
Starting specializations	2 Physical + 1 Mental, Social, or Knowledge
Additional rule	May replace any number of starting species natural-weapon competencies with crafted-weapon competencies.

ARTISAN

The Artisan transforms matter, tools, and resources into useful, beautiful, or dangerous objects.

TRAIT	VALUE
Major affinity	Arts and Crafts
Starting specializations	2 Arts and Crafts + 1 from any category

WANDERER

The Wanderer was shaped by the road, adaptation, observation, and survival away from a stable place.

TRAIT	VALUE
Major affinity	Mental
Starting specializations	2 Mental + 1 Physical, Social, or Knowledge

CUSTODIAN

The Custodian comes from traditions, institutions, or duties tied to protecting knowledge, memory, or relics.

TRAIT	VALUE
Major affinity	Knowledge
Starting specializations	2 Knowledge + 1 Physical, Mental, or Social

NOBLE

The Noble was raised among hierarchy, education, influence, duty, or social ties.

TRAIT	VALUE
Major affinity	Social
Starting specializations	1 Social + 2 from any other category

At the end of this step, record:

- your background
 - your major affinity
 - the categories allowed for your three starting specializations
-

5. SELECT STARTING SPECIALIZATIONS

Each character begins with three specializations granted by background.

These specializations must follow the restrictions of the chosen background.

Each starting specialization:

- begins at level 1
- begins at Novice rank
- activates Synapsis
- cannot be repeated during character creation

Starting specialization = level 1 / Novice rank

In addition, every character receives one universal starting Tenacity specialization.

Choose one:

- **March**
- **Acclimation**
- **Tolerance**

This specialization also begins at level 1, Novice rank, and activates Synapsis.

You cannot choose the same specialization twice. If a specialization was already chosen through background, it cannot be repeated as the universal choice.

At the end of this step, your character should have four starting specializations:

SOURCE	AMOUNT
Background	3 specializations
Universal Tenacity choice	1 specialization
Total	4 starting specializations

The complete list of specializations appears in the **Specialization Catalog**.

6. APPLY SYNAPSIS

Synapsis represents how practice modifies the character's characteristics.

Each specialization is associated with a characteristic. When a specialization reaches a new rank, that characteristic increases by `+1`.

During character creation, all starting specializations begin at Novice rank. For that reason, each one grants `+1` to its associated characteristic.

```
Synapsis from starting specialization = +1 to associated characteristic
```

This includes:

- the three background specializations
- the universal Tenacity specialization

HOW TO APPLY SYNAPSIS

For each starting specialization:

1. Check its associated characteristic.
2. Add `+1` to that characteristic.
3. Repeat this process for all four starting specializations.

If several specializations are associated with the same characteristic, their increases stack.

```
Final characteristic = species bonus + applied Synapsis
```

At the end of this step, all final characteristics should be calculated.

7. CALCULATE DERIVED ATTRIBUTES

Derived attributes are calculated after applying species and Synapsis.

During character creation, calculate these derived attributes:

- **Preparation**
- **Resilience**

- **Endurance**
- **Sanity**

These values use the character's final characteristics.

PREPARATION

Preparation measures how well the character anticipates, reacts, and acts under pressure.

$$\text{Preparation} = (\text{Agility} + \text{Cunning} + \text{Composure}) / 3$$

Minimum value: 1.

RESILIENCE

Resilience measures the character's ability to resist and recover from adverse alterations.

$$\text{Resilience} = (\text{Tenacity} + \text{Wisdom} + \text{Composure}) / 3$$

Minimum value: 1.

ENDURANCE

Endurance measures how much accumulated strain the character can sustain before entering Fatigue.

$$\text{Endurance} = 3 + (\text{Tenacity} \times 2)$$

The universal starting Tenacity specialization is already included indirectly, because it applies Synapsis and increases Tenacity during character creation.

SANITY

Sanity measures the character's base mental and emotional stability against extreme pressure, horror, corruption, or effects that attack internal balance.

$$\text{Sanity} = \text{Composure} \times 2$$

Minimum value: 1.

The full interaction between Sanity, cosmic horror, corruption, and equipment appears in their corresponding sections. During character creation, record the base value so the sheet is complete.

ROUNDING

If Preparation or Resilience produces fractions or decimals, round up.

1.1 → 2

1.6 → 2

2.0 → 2

Endurance and Sanity do not require rounding with their current formulas.

If a permanent characteristic increases later, recalculate any derived attribute that depends on it.

BRIEF EXAMPLE

After applying species and Synopsis, a character has:

CHARACTERISTIC	VALUE
Agility	2
Cunning	1
Composure	1
Tenacity	2
Wisdom	1

Calculate Preparation:

```
Preparation = (2 + 1 + 1) / 3
Preparation = 4 / 3
Preparation = 2
```

Calculate Resilience:

```
Resilience = (2 + 1 + 1) / 3
Resilience = 4 / 3
Resilience = 2
```

Calculate Endurance:

```
Endurance = 3 + (2 × 2)
Endurance = 7
```

Calculate Sanity:

```
Sanity = 1 × 2
Sanity = 2
```

Preparation and Resilience are rounded up.

8. CHOOSE PERSONALITY TRAITS

Personality Traits describe how the character thinks, feels, and responds to the world.

They can also be used in play. If a trait clearly influences a scene, the player may propose a **Personality Trait Roll** instead of a Characteristic Roll or Specialization Roll. The Narrator decides whether the justification is valid.

You can choose traits in two ways.

STRUCTURED OPTION

Choose one trait for each factor:

FACTOR	WHAT IT DESCRIBES
Openness to Experience	Relationship with the new, uncertain, abstract, or imaginative
Conscientiousness	Discipline, order, consistency, and responsibility
Extraversion	Way of occupying social space
Agreeableness	Empathy, cooperation, trust, or reserve toward others
Neuroticism	Emotional stability and response to anxiety, pressure, or internal conflict

Each trait must have an intensity:

- high
- low

Intensity does not mean “better” or “worse.” It defines how that factor expresses itself in the character.

FREE OPTION

Choose five traits without assigning them to factors.

They can be single words or short phrases:

- restless
- analytical
- loyal
- impulsive
- somber
- distrustful
- protective
- curious

This option works the same in play. Any trait can be invoked if the player explains how it affects the scene and the Narrator accepts the justification.

At the end of this step, your character should have:

- five Personality Traits, or
- one trait for each factor with high or low intensity

The complete list of suggested traits appears in the **Personality Traits** section.

9. RECORD ADDITIONAL SPECIES ATTRIBUTES

Before finishing, review the full profile of your species and record any element not already written on the sheet.

This may include:

- size
- height and weight
- languages
- speed
- heritage
- legacy
- other equivalent starting values
- bodily attacks or natural weapons
- variant
- additional special capabilities
- usage restrictions
- situational bonuses

You do not need to copy all cultural or narrative information from the species entry. You should record every mechanical effect and functional trait that may be used during play.

CHARACTER CREATION CLOSURE

At the end of character creation, your character should have:

ELEMENT	STATUS
Concept	Defined
Species	Chosen
Background	Chosen
Major affinity	Recorded
Characteristics	Calculated with species and Synapsis
Starting specializations	3 from background + 1 universal Tenacity choice
Preparation	Calculated
Resilience	Calculated
Endurance	Calculated
Sanity	Calculated
Personality Traits	Chosen
Additional species attributes	Recorded

With this, the character is ready to enter play.

EXAMPLE

A player creates an explorer from a species with an Agility bonus.

First, they record every characteristic at 0. Then they choose species and apply the Agility bonus along with any other characteristics indicated by that species.

Next, they choose a background that grants three starting specializations. They also choose **Acclimation** as the universal Tenacity specialization.

They now have four starting specializations. Each one is level 1, Novice rank, so each one activates Synapsis and increases its associated characteristic by +1.

Only after applying species and Synapsis do they calculate Preparation, Resilience, Endurance, and Sanity.

The order matters because each step modifies the next.

ACTIONS

In combat and high-pressure scenes, every action has a place within the temporal flow. Some actions consume a creature's normal activation. Others happen in response to a trigger. Others are brief enough that they do not need a cost of their own.

Actions are divided into three types:

- **Active Actions**
- **Reactions**
- **Free Actions**

This division does not replace the **ATB** timeline. It indicates how each action enters that system.

ACTION TYPES

TYPE	WHEN IT OCCURS	ATB EFFECT
Active Action	During the creature's normal activation	Advances the marker by rhythm cost
Reaction	When a trigger allows a response outside normal activation	Advances the marker if the reaction has a rhythm cost
Free Action	At a reasonable moment in the scene	Does not usually advance the marker

ACTIVE ACTIONS

An **Active Action** is a deliberate action performed during a creature's normal activation on the ATB timeline.

An Active Action:

- occurs during the creature's normal activation
- has a rhythm cost
- may generate Attrition
- clearly changes the state of the scene

Attacking, moving, hiding, interacting under pressure, or using a specialization in combat are usually Active Actions.

REACTIONS

A **Reaction** is an action allowed by a trigger.

It does not occur because the creature has reached its normal activation, but because something in the scene allows or demands an immediate response.

A Reaction can be used to:

- respond to an incoming threat
- protect oneself
- cover another creature
- interrupt an action
- deflect an attack
- exploit an opening
- activate a Technique with a reactive trigger

Reactions are not free. If a Reaction has a rhythm cost, it advances the creature's marker on the ATB. If it generates Attrition, that Attrition is accumulated normally.

A creature can only use a Reaction when a rule, Technique, maneuver, trait, or specific situation allows it.

FREE ACTIONS

A **Free Action** is a brief action that does not justify a rhythm cost or Attrition by itself.

It is used for minimal gestures, immediate coordination, or details that let the scene flow without turning everything into a formal activation.

Examples:

- dropping an object
- saying a brief phrase
- pointing in a direction
- nodding or shaking the head
- issuing a short warning
- adjusting posture without changing the situation

An action is not free only because it seems small. If it changes the scene in a meaningful way, demands precision under pressure, substitutes an Active Action, or is repeated to create advantages without cost, the Narrator may assign rhythm cost, Attrition, or both.

Free Actions exist to preserve flow, not to multiply effects without cost.

RHYTHM COSTS

Rhythm costs indicate how far the creature’s marker advances on the ATB timeline after acting.

CATEGORY	RHYTHM COST
Free	0
Quick	3
Standard	5
Heavy	7
Variable	Defined by the rule, Technique, or effect

Rhythm cost does not always measure physical duration. It also measures recovery, exposure, commitment, and lost opportunity within combat.

BASE ACTIONS

These actions are available to any character in combat or in a high-pressure scene.

ACTION	TYPE	RHYTHM	BASE ATTRITION
Movement	Active Action	5	1
Natural weapon attack	Active Action	5	1
One-handed weapon attack	Active Action	5	1
Two-handed weapon attack	Active Action	7	1
Two-weapon attack	Active Action	7	1
Interact	Active Action	3	0 or 1
Hide	Active Action	5	1
Use Specialization	Active Action	5	1
Use Technique	Variable	Variable	Variable
Drop	Free Action	0	0
Speak briefly	Free Action	0	0

The listed Attrition is the base cost. Rules, conditions, Techniques, or circumstances may modify it.

MOVEMENT

A **Movement** represents deliberate displacement within a combat or high-pressure scene.

It can be used to:

- advance toward a position
- retreat
- flank
- cross a dangerous zone
- reach cover
- separate from a threat

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 5

Attrition: 1

The base distance comes from the character's species speed. Terrain does not change the rhythm cost. It changes how far the character moves, whether the path requires a roll, or what consequences the movement produces.

CONDITION	EFFECT ON DISTANCE
Difficult terrain	Half speed
Crawling	Half speed
Running	Double speed

Swimming, climbing, and jumping are part of Movement when used to travel through space. Each may require an appropriate Specialization Roll: **Swim**, **Climb**, or **Jump**.

The Narrator calls for the roll before or during the Movement depending on the risk of the path.

ATTACK

An attack is a direct attempt to deal damage or physical pressure to a target.

Every attack is resolved with an **Attack Roll (A.R.)** unless a specific rule states otherwise. The attack family determines rhythm cost, Attrition, and any additional procedure.

NATURAL WEAPONS

Natural weapons are offensive body parts: claws, bite, horns, tail, pincers, stingers, or similar structures.

They require no equipment and cannot be disarmed as long as the creature's body can use them.

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 5

Attrition: 1

Resolved with a standard A.R. using the corresponding competency and associated characteristic.

ONE-HANDED WEAPON

A one-handed weapon attack uses a weapon that can be held and operated with one hand: short sword, axe, mace, combat dagger, or equivalent weapon.

This attack leaves the other hand free.

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 5

Attrition: 1

Resolved with a standard A.R.

TWO-HANDED WEAPON

A two-handed weapon attack uses a weapon that requires full-body commitment: greatsword, war axe, spear held with both hands, great maul, or equivalent weapon.

These weapons often have greater reach, mass, or threat, but they delay the user's next intervention.

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 7

Attrition: 1

Resolved with a standard A.R.

The character returns to the ATB later than with other base attacks.

TWO WEAPONS

Fighting with two weapons allows the character to chain attacks within the same activation. The main hand performs the initial attack. Additional attacks depend on the character's coordination under pressure.

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 7

Attrition: 1

Procedure:

1. Make an **initial A.R.** with the main hand, without penalty.
2. Make a **dual-wield combat S.R.** against the target's D.R.
3. If the S.R. exceeds the D.R., you may declare additional attacks.

4. Additional attacks alternate between both hands.

The S.R. uses the **Dual-Wield Combat** specialization and **Agility** as the associated characteristic.

The character gains **1** additional attack for every **2** points of Agility, with a minimum of **1**.

INTERACT

Interact covers brief physical interventions that are neither attacks nor movement.

It can be used to:

- take an object
- pick something up from the ground
- open or close something
- activate a mechanism
- adjust equipment
- store or draw an accessible object

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 3

Attrition: 1 under real pressure

Attrition is only generated when the interaction occurs under active scene pressure. A trivial interaction with no immediate risk does not generate Attrition.

WEAPON CHANGE

Changing the weapon the character holds requires two Interact actions:

1. set aside or store the current weapon
2. draw the new weapon

If the character first drops the current weapon as a Free Action, only one Interact action is needed to draw the new weapon.

HIDE

Hide is the deliberate attempt to leave the enemies' precise localization.

It does not make the character invisible. It does not erase tracks. It creates doubt about exactly where the character is and where they can act from.

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 5

Attrition: 1

To hide, the character needs a real opportunity. They must meet at least one of these conditions:

- have Medium or Total Cover
- be outside effective visual range
- exploit reduced Visibility
- use a sufficient distraction
- have a Technique, trait, artifact, or preparation that allows hiding

A character cannot vanish in plain sight while a relevant enemy clearly has them localized through an applicable sense. If someone sees, hears, smells, or otherwise perceives them without obstruction, the character must first break that localization.

Hide is resolved with a Specialization Roll appropriate to the fiction, such as **Stealth**, **Survival**, or another specialization authorized by a Technique.

The roll is compared against the environment difficulty or enemy Perception. On success, the character gains **Concealment** against the affected enemies.

The full rules for Concealment, approximate position, and detection are found in **Cover**, **Visibility**, and **Concealment**.

USE SPECIALIZATION

Using a **Specialization** means applying a trained skill within a hostile or high-pressure scene.

It can cover actions such as:

- jumping an obstacle
- climbing under threat

- swimming against a current
- tracking while moving
- interpreting an inscription before an enemy arrives
- reading an adversary's body language
- crafting or adjusting something under pressure

Type: Active Action

Rhythm cost: 5

Attrition: 1

A Specialization produces a narrative or practical result: the character clears the gap, deciphers the code, detects the trap, or reaches a position.

If that result has a direct mechanical consequence, that consequence must come from a specific rule, a later action, or a Technique.

USE TECHNIQUE

A **Technique** is a trained application that produces a defined mechanical consequence.

Where a Specialization opens a possibility, a Technique turns that possibility into an immediate effect.

Type: Variable

Rhythm cost: Defined by the Technique

Attrition: Defined by the Technique

Most Techniques are Active Actions. Some function as Reactions if they have a trigger that allows it.

The full catalog of Techniques and their activation conditions is found in the **Techniques** chapter.

DROP

Drop covers letting go of an object the character is holding, as long as that object is not committed to an active maneuver.

Type: Free Action

Rhythm cost: 0

Attrition: 0

This covers:

- dropping a weapon from the inactive hand
- letting go of an object before or after the main action
- releasing something that is no longer part of what the character is doing

An object that is part of an active grapple, struggle, block, joint maneuver, or committed situation cannot be dropped for free. In that case, it requires an Interact action.

SPEAK

Speak covers brief communication that does not try to alter another creature's will, emotion, or decision.

Type: Free Action

Rhythm cost: 0

Attrition: 0

This covers:

- a brief warning
- a tactical signal
- a short command directed at an ally
- an involuntary exclamation
- a phrase that transmits immediate information

Deceiving, persuading, negotiating, intimidating, calming, or provoking is not free. The distinction does not depend only on the length of the phrase, but on its function.

Transmitting immediate information can be free. Trying to influence another participant requires an appropriate action.

EXAMPLE

A character holds a corridor while an ally withdraws.

They can shout "Left!" as a Free Action because the phrase only transmits immediate information.

If that same character tries to calm a panicking ally, provoke an enemy, or force a surrender, it is no longer free. The action now tries to alter another participant's decision state and must be resolved through the appropriate action structure.

ATB: THE COMBAT TIMELINE

Combat is not divided into fixed rounds. Each creature acts according to its position on the timeline, its Preparation, and the rhythm cost of its actions.

The combat timeline, or **ATB**, represents when a creature is ready to act and how long it takes to become ready again.

Each participant occupies a position on a track. The marker furthest to the left acts first. After acting, that marker advances to the right according to the rhythm cost of the chosen action.

The ATB answers two questions:

Who acts now?

How long until they act again?

WHAT THE ATB REPRESENTS

A marker's position on the track does not represent only initiative. It represents the time a creature needs to recover, reorganize, and generate another meaningful action.

A quick action leaves the creature available sooner. A heavy action delays it more.

The track shows:

- who acts first
- who acts again sooner
- who overcommits
- who delays their next opportunity through a heavy action
- who gains tempo through lighter actions

The combat order is not fixed at the beginning. It changes with every activation.

COMBAT OPENING

When a hostile scene begins, each participant receives an initial position on the ATB.

To do this, each participant calculates their **Opening Value**.

Opening Value = Preparation + situational modifiers

The highest Opening Value among all participants establishes the encounter's **Reference Point**.

Reference Point = highest Opening Value in the encounter

Each participant's initial position is calculated with this formula:

Initial position = Reference Point - participant's Opening Value

The participant with the highest Opening Value starts at position **0**, the leftmost point on the track. That participant acts first.

All other participants start to the right, at a distance equal to the difference between the Reference Point and their own Opening Value.

SITUATIONAL MODIFIERS

Situational modifiers represent advantages or disadvantages at the start of combat.

They may include:

- being alert
- ambushing
- being surprised
- having a weapon ready
- being distracted
- being wounded
- being poorly positioned
- reorganizing

- starting from an advantageous position

The Narrator assigns these modifiers according to the fiction of the scene.

The combat opening is not a separate system from the ATB. It only defines the track's starting state. From the first activation onward, rhythm costs apply normally.

OPENING EXAMPLE

Three creatures begin an encounter.

PARTICIPANT	PREPARATION	MODIFIER	OPENING VALUE
Explorer	4	+1	5
Beast	3	0	3
Custodian	2	-1	1

The highest Opening Value is **5**, so the Reference Point is **5**.

PARTICIPANT	CALCULATION	INITIAL POSITION
Explorer	5 - 5	0
Beast	5 - 3	2
Custodian	5 - 1	4

The Explorer acts first because they are at position **0**. The Beast starts at position **2**. The Custodian starts at position **4**.

ATB FLOW

Once the opening is resolved, combat follows the normal ATB flow.

To resolve order:

1. The leftmost marker acts.
2. The creature resolves its action.

3. The marker advances to the right by the rhythm cost of that action.
4. Check again which marker is now furthest to the left.
5. That marker acts next.

Combat repeats this procedure until the scene ends.

ACTIVATION

A creature activates when its marker is furthest to the left on the track.

During its activation, it can take an available action according to the rules for Actions, Techniques, active conditions, and the current state of the scene.

After the action is resolved, its marker advances to the right.

$$\text{New position} = \text{current position} + \text{rhythm cost of the action}$$

A quick action moves the marker a short distance. A heavy action moves it farther.

TIEBREAKING

If two or more markers occupy the same leftmost position, the participant with the higher Preparation acts first.

If Preparation is also tied, each tied participant makes a contested Agility Characteristic Roll.

The highest result acts first.

If the tie remains, the Narrator decides according to position, the fiction of the scene, or any clear situational advantage.

RHYTHM COST

Every significant action has a **rhythm cost**.

This cost indicates how much the action delays the creature's next opportunity to act.

Rhythm cost is not the same as Attrition.

CONCEPT	WHAT IT MEASURES
Rhythm	How long the creature takes to act again
Attrition	How much accumulated pressure the action leaves on body, mind, or composure

An action can be quick but exhausting. It can also be slow without generating much Attrition.

Rhythm organizes time. Attrition records the internal cost of sustaining action.

ACTION BANDS

Every action has a rhythm cost. That number indicates how many positions the marker advances to the right after the action is resolved.

BAND	RHYTHM COST
Free action	0
Quick action	3
Standard action	5
Heavy action	7
Extreme action	9
Variable	Defined by the rule, Technique, or effect

Extreme actions are not available as base actions. They appear through Techniques, special effects, or specific rules.

An action with cost 0 does not advance the marker. This does not mean it can be used without limit. Free Actions remain subject to the limits defined in the Actions chapter.

BASE ACTIONS AND RHYTHM

These costs apply when no Technique, specific rule, condition, or bonus modifies them.

ACTION	RHYTHM COST	BASE ATTRITION
Free action: drop, speak briefly	0	0
Interact	3	0 or 1
Move	5	1
Hide	5	1
Use Specialization	5	1
Attack with natural weapon	5	1
Attack with one-handed weapon	5	1
Attack with two-handed weapon	7	1
Attack with two weapons	7	1
Use Technique	Variable	Variable

Interact only generates Attrition when the interaction occurs under real scene pressure. A trivial interaction with no immediate risk generates 0 Attrition.

ACTIONS WITH COST 0

An action with rhythm cost 0 does not move the marker on the ATB.

This applies to brief actions such as dropping an object or saying a short phrase, within the limits defined in the Actions chapter.

Cost 0 does not make an action unlimited. If a Free Action changes the scene in a meaningful way, replaces an Active Action, or is repeated to create advantages without cost, the Narrator may assign rhythm cost, Attrition, or both.

REACTIONS AND ATB

Reactions exist within the same temporal economy as every other action.

Even though they occur outside a creature's normal activation, they may have:

- rhythm cost
- Attrition cost
- effects on the marker's future position

If a Reaction has a rhythm cost, the creature's marker advances from its current position.

$$\text{New position} = \text{current position} + \text{rhythm cost of the Reaction}$$

The advantage of a Reaction is not that it is free. Its advantage is that it allows the creature to intervene now, before its next normal activation.

A creature can only use a Reaction when a rule, Technique, maneuver, trait, or specific situation allows it.

The full definition of Reactions is found in the Actions chapter.

MOVEMENT AND ATB

Movement is not a separate layer from combat. It is part of the scene's rhythm and has its own cost.

Moving always occupies the Standard band of the ATB.

$$\text{Movement} = \text{rhythm cost } 5$$

Moving to escape a breath attack, reach cover, close distance, or intercept a charge costs the same on the track. What changes is what that movement achieves.

Terrain does not modify rhythm cost. Terrain can modify:

- distance covered
- required rolls
- consequences of the path
- hazards crossed

Position determines what is possible. That is the tactical value of Movement within the ATB.

HIDE AND ATB

Hide uses standard rhythm because it requires a real opening within the scene.

Hide = rhythm cost 5

To hide, the character must create or exploit a situation that allows them to break the enemies' precise localization.

Hide cannot be declared without cover, reduced visibility, distraction, preparation, or a specific rule that allows it.

The full rules for Concealment, approximate position, and detection are found in **Cover, Visibility, and Concealment**.

TECHNIQUES AND VARIABLE COSTS

Techniques can modify the normal flow of the ATB.

A Technique can:

- use a different rhythm cost
- reduce or increase Attrition
- function as a Reaction
- create an exception to the normal order
- move markers
- alter a creature's position on the track

When a Technique contradicts a general ATB rule, the specific rule of the Technique applies.

EXAMPLE

Two characters begin near the same point on the timeline.

The first uses Movement to gain cover. That action has rhythm cost 5, so their marker advances 5 positions.

The second uses a two-handed weapon attack. That action has rhythm cost 7, so their marker advances 7 positions.

The first character becomes available again sooner because they paid a lower rhythm cost. The second created more immediate pressure, but will take longer to act again.

The timeline records those choices directly, without converting them into fixed rounds.

ATTRITION, ENDURANCE, AND FATIGUE

Combat and high-pressure scenes do not only threaten a character's life. They also wear down the body, mind, and composure.

This system uses three values:

VALUE	WHAT IT REPRESENTS
Attrition	The accumulated burden of acting under pressure
Endurance	How much Attrition the character can sustain before deteriorating
Fatigue	The deterioration that appears when Attrition exceeds Endurance

Attrition does not replace damage. It also does not replace activation order. It tracks how much effort a character can continue to sustain before their performance begins to break.

ATTRITION

Attrition is the accumulated burden a character bears when performing meaningful actions in a hostile or high-pressure scene.

It does not represent direct physical damage. It also includes physical effort, concentration, tactical reading, emotional control, and immediate response to danger.

A character can accumulate Attrition from:

- attacking, defending, or moving in combat
- reacting to sudden threats
- sustaining a demanding maneuver

- analyzing a creature under pressure
- applying mental or social pressure in a conflictive scene
- acting while suffering adverse conditions or environmental pressure

Not every action generates Attrition. Only actions that demand real effort and carry weight within the scene do.

ATTRITION COSTS

Actions use a simple cost scale.

COST	ACTION TYPE
0	Action with no real demand
1	Standard meaningful action
2	High-demand action
3	Extreme or overextension action

0 ATTRITION

Trivial or purely narrative actions that impose no real effort within the scene.

Examples:

- an obvious observation
 - a brief remark with no tactical weight
 - a minor action with no immediate threat
-

1 ATTRITION

Standard meaningful actions.

Examples:

- a standard attack
- a simple defense

- significant movement under pressure
 - active observation of an enemy
 - a basic reading of a creature's behavior
-

2 ATTRITION

High-demand actions.

Examples:

- intercepting a charge
 - protecting another character by absorbing pressure
 - deeply analyzing an enemy during combat
 - executing a maneuver that changes the rhythm of the scene
 - using a mental or social action that removes an important advantage
-

3 ATTRITION

Extreme or overextension actions.

Examples:

- a limit effort while the character is already under heavy pressure
 - a heroic intervention beyond the character's safe margin
 - an especially demanding maneuver that forces the character beyond their normal rhythm
-

PHYSICAL, MENTAL, AND SOCIAL ACTIONS

Attrition does not depend on the type of characteristic used. It depends on the real demand of the action.

A mental or social action can generate Attrition if it:

- requires real focus under threat
- changes the tactical situation
- competes with other important combat actions
- forces the character to sustain reading, control, or pressure in the middle of chaos

Not every mental or social action generates Attrition. Only those that provide a real advantage or impose a meaningful burden under pressure do.

Reading a creature, breaking its pattern, forcing a reaction, or destabilizing its behavior can cost as much as attacking or defending, if the situation warrants it.

REACTIONS AND ATTRITION

Reactions are not costly because they are Reactions. They are costly because of the demand they imply.

Responding outside a character’s natural rhythm usually requires precision, tension, and speed. For that reason, a Reaction may cost more or less Attrition depending on how difficult it is to execute.

REACTION TYPE	SUGGESTED ATTRITION
Simple Reaction	1
Demanding Reaction	2
Limit Reaction	3

What matters is not the action category, but its intensity within the scene.

ENDURANCE

Endurance represents how much accumulated burden a character can sustain before beginning to suffer Fatigue.

Every character has a minimum reserve of function. This reserve covers three planes of conflict:

- the **body**, which sustains effort, impact, and movement
- the **mind**, which sustains attention, reading, and interpretation
- **composure**, which sustains control, intent, and clarity under pressure

Every character has a base Endurance reserve of 3 . To that base, add the character’s final bodily resistance, expressed through Tenacity.

Endurance = 3 + (Tenacity × 2)

The Tenacity used in this formula is the character's final Tenacity, after applying species and Synopsis.

Every character begins with one starting Tenacity specialization at level 1, Novice rank: **March**, **Acclimation**, or **Tolerance**. That specialization is already included indirectly in Endurance because it increases Tenacity through Synopsis during character creation.

EXAMPLE

A character finishes creation with Tenacity **2**.

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Endurance} &= 3 + (2 \times 2) \\ \text{Endurance} &= 7\end{aligned}$$

That character has Endurance **7**.

FATIGUE

Fatigue is the progressive deterioration that appears when a character accumulates more Attrition than they can sustain.

It does not come from a single isolated action. It comes from accumulation.

As Attrition increases, it becomes harder for the character to maintain precision, keep pace, preserve clarity, or respond with firmness.

Fatigue can reflect:

- bodily saturation
 - cognitive overload
 - loss of composure
 - difficulty sustaining the same performance
 - general deterioration after a demanding scene
-

PROJECTED FATIGUE AND SETTLED FATIGUE

Fatigue is handled in two moments: while the scene is still active, and when the scene ends.

PROJECTED FATIGUE

During a hostile scene, the character tracks accumulated Attrition and calculates what Fatigue level they would suffer if the scene ended at that moment.

That Fatigue is still **projected**.

This means the character is pushing their margin, but the full penalty does not settle while adrenaline, urgency, or immediate danger continue to support performance.

During combat, Fatigue is projected.

SETTLED FATIGUE

When the hostile scene ends or clearly drops in intensity, Projected Fatigue becomes real Fatigue.

At that moment:

1. Check accumulated Attrition.
2. Determine the Fatigue level reached.
3. Apply that level as Settled Fatigue.
4. Clear the accumulated Attrition from that scene, unless a specific rule says otherwise.

When combat ends, Fatigue settles.

FATIGUE THRESHOLDS

Fatigue is determined by comparing accumulated Attrition with the character's Endurance.

LEVEL	CONDITION
Fatigue 0	Attrition is lower than Endurance
Fatigue 1	Attrition is equal to or greater than Endurance
Fatigue 2	Attrition is equal to or greater than 2 × Endurance
Fatigue 3	Attrition is equal to or greater than 3 × Endurance
Fatigue 4	Attrition is equal to or greater than 4 × Endurance
Fatigue 5	Attrition is equal to or greater than 5 × Endurance

The base scale does not exceed Fatigue 5.

If a mechanic adds Fatigue while the character is already at Fatigue 5, the character becomes **Incapacitated by exhaustion**.

EXAMPLE OF THRESHOLDS

If a character has Endurance 7 :

ACCUMULATED ATTRITION	PROJECTED OR SETTLED FATIGUE
0–6	Fatigue 0
7–13	Fatigue 1
14–20	Fatigue 2
21–27	Fatigue 3
28–34	Fatigue 4
35 or more	Fatigue 5

Fatigue 5 is not a tactical margin that can be sustained voluntarily. It is the final point before operational collapse.

INCAPACITATED BY EXHAUSTION

A character **Incapacitated by exhaustion** cannot take:

- Active Actions
- Reactions
- Techniques

They must begin resting as soon as the scene allows it.

If the environment prevents rest, they need help, shelter, transport, or a specific rule to avoid being removed from action.

CARRYING CAPACITY

Sustained load does not use scene Attrition when measured as prolonged travel, exploration, transport, or physical work.

In those cases, it generates Fatigue directly over time.

Carrying capacity depends on three factors:

- creature size
- Strength
- Tenacity

To prevent a character with Strength or Tenacity from having capacity , use minimum effective values.

```
Effective Strength = max(Strength, 1)
Effective Tenacity = max(Tenacity, 1)
Carrying capacity = Effective Strength × Effective Tenacity × size
multiplier
```

SIZE	CARRYING CAPACITY
Tiny	Effective Strength × Effective Tenacity × 1 kg
Small	Effective Strength × Effective Tenacity × 15 kg
Medium	Effective Strength × Effective Tenacity × 35 kg
Large	Effective Strength × Effective Tenacity × 80 kg
Huge	Effective Strength × Effective Tenacity × 200 kg
Gigantic	Effective Strength × Effective Tenacity × 800 kg

LOAD TYPE

Load type is determined by the percentage of total capacity being used.

LOAD TYPE	WEIGHT CARRIED	SUSTAINED LOAD FATIGUE
Light Load	Up to 50% of capacity	Does not generate automatic Fatigue
Medium Load	More than 50% and up to 75%	+1 Fatigue level every 2 hours
Heavy Load	More than 75% and up to 100%	+1 Fatigue level every 1 hour

A load above 100% of capacity cannot be carried functionally without help, equipment, Technique, pack creature, or a specific rule.

Sustained load Fatigue does not check Attrition thresholds. It is added directly over time.

If a new application of sustained load Fatigue would push the character beyond Fatigue 5, they become **Incapacitated by exhaustion**.

QUICK SUMMARY

ELEMENT	RULE
Attrition	Accumulates from meaningful actions under pressure
Endurance	$3 + (\text{Tenacity} \times 2)$
Projected Fatigue	Calculated during the scene, but not settled yet
Settled Fatigue	Applied when the hostile scene ends or intensity drops
Fatigue 1	Attrition equal to or greater than Endurance
Fatigue 5	Maximum base Fatigue level
Beyond Fatigue 5	Incapacitated by exhaustion
Sustained load	Adds Fatigue directly over time, not through Attrition thresholds

EXAMPLE

A creature with Endurance **7** participates in a long combat.

During the scene, it accumulates **15** points of Attrition. While combat remains active, that Fatigue is projected.

```
Endurance = 7
Accumulated Attrition = 15
Projected Fatigue = 2
```

The character continues acting while the scene continues, unless another rule says otherwise.

When combat ends, Fatigue settles. The character receives Fatigue 2 and clears the accumulated Attrition from that scene.

If they rest later, they can reduce Fatigue according to the Rest rules.

REST

Rest is the primary way a character recovers control after a demanding scene.

A combat, a chase, a hostile traverse, or an intense confrontation leaves more than visible Wounds. It also leaves heavy breathing, tension, mental saturation, loss of composure, and Fatigue.

Resting does not reset a character. It restores part of the margin they lost.

Rest serves four functions:

- reduce Fatigue
- allow Wound treatment
- allow maintenance, repair, and preparation
- give the group space to reorganize before returning to danger

Not all rest offers the same recovery. A brief pause can return some control, but it can also expose the group to interruption. A long rest allows deeper recovery, but it requires time, adequate conditions, and relative safety.

REST, ATTRITION, AND FATIGUE

During a hostile scene, the character accumulates **Attrition**.

While the scene remains active, that Attrition generates **Projected Fatigue**. When the scene ends or clearly drops in intensity, that Fatigue settles and the accumulated Attrition from the scene is cleared, unless a specific rule says otherwise.

Rest does not exist to erase an infinite Attrition count. It exists to reduce **Settled Fatigue** and allow the character to recover functionality.

In summary:

MOMENT	WHAT HAPPENS
During the scene	The character accumulates Attrition and calculates Projected Fatigue
When the scene ends	Projected Fatigue becomes Settled Fatigue
During rest	The character can reduce Settled Fatigue and perform recovery tasks

TYPES OF REST

There are two main forms of rest:

- **Short Rest**
- **Full Rest**

Each responds to a different need.

REST	DURATION	MAIN FUNCTION
Short Rest	15, 30, or 60 minutes	Partial recovery, stabilization, and immediate preparation
Full Rest	8 hours or more	Deep recovery, treatment, and extended reorganization

SHORT REST

A **Short Rest** represents a brief pause to catch breath, stabilize the body, check resources, and recover some control before continuing.

It does not mean leaving danger behind completely. It is a functional pause within the adventure.

The group can choose one of three durations:

- 15 minutes
- 30 minutes
- 60 minutes

The longer the rest, the greater the possible recovery. It also increases the risk of being detected, interrupted, or caught off guard if the location is not safe.

15-MINUTE REST

A 15-minute rest represents a brief respite.

It is enough to slow breathing, organize equipment, drink water, check the group's condition, and recover a minimum of control.

Effect:

- reduces 1 level of Settled Fatigue from one character, if they have Fatigue 1 or higher
- allows 1 brief maintenance or preparation task

Available brief tasks:

- adjust a strap or piece of equipment
- reorganize a weapon or tool
- quickly check a Wound
- exchange immediate information
- decide a route or simple tactical priority
- assign basic watch or positions

This rest is useful when the group does not want to stop for long, but needs to stabilize before pressing forward.

30-MINUTE REST

A 30-minute rest represents a real brief recovery pause.

It is more than catching breath. It allows the group to recover functional margin and dedicate attention to one more meaningful task.

Effect:

- reduces 1 level of Settled Fatigue from each resting character
- allows 1 significant maintenance, treatment, or preparation task

Available significant tasks:

- stabilize a Light Wound with Medicine, if the proper kit is available
- study a recent clue
- review tracks, maps, or notes
- distribute resources
- clean or adjust equipment used in the previous scene
- prepare an immediate route

This is the most stable form of Short Rest. It offers useful recovery without fully abandoning the rhythm of the expedition.

60-MINUTE REST

A 60-minute rest represents a deep pause within the day, without becoming a full sleep.

The character has enough time to recover bodily control, clear the mind, and address immediate consequences more effectively.

Effect:

- reduces 2 levels of Settled Fatigue from each resting character
- allows up to 2 maintenance, treatment, or preparation tasks

If conditions are favorable, the Narrator may allow one of these additional benefits:

- reduce 1 additional level of Settled Fatigue
- allow one additional task
- reduce the risk of an unexpected event

The Narrator may consider conditions favorable if the group has:

- reasonable shelter
- warmth or protection from the elements
- water and food
- organized watch
- space to sit or lie down
- appropriate tools for treating the body or equipment

During a 60-minute Rest, a character can attempt to stabilize a Severe Wound with Medicine, if the proper kit is available.

This rest does not free Wound Slots.

SHORT RECOVERY LIMIT

To prevent the group from chaining pauses until all adventure pressure disappears, only the first Short Rest taken after a significant scene reduces Fatigue normally.

Subsequent pauses before a new significant scene can still be used to:

- talk
- plan
- keep watch
- reorganize equipment
- treat Wounds
- prepare resources
- review information

But they do not reduce Fatigue again unless a specific rule allows it.

A brief pause can stabilize you. It does not replace real recovery and cannot be repeated indefinitely to erase the cost of danger.

FULL REST

A **Full Rest** represents a true interruption of the day.

It requires at least **8** hours of rest, sleep, or equivalent recovery under reasonably adequate conditions.

It is not only a physical need. It is also the moment when characters recenter themselves, organize the next day, share information, repair equipment, address persistent consequences, and recover part of what the adventure has taken from them.

1. FATIGUE RECOVERY

A Full Rest reduces the character's Settled Fatigue by **3** levels.

Fatigue recovered by Full Rest = 3 levels

If conditions are especially favorable, the Narrator may allow the character to recover **1** additional Fatigue level.

Especially favorable conditions may include:

- safe shelter
- uninterrupted sleep
- enough food and water
- adequate temperature
- available medical attention
- no immediate threats

Fatigue cannot drop below **0**.

2. PERSISTENT ATTRITION RECOVERY

Some specific rules may cause certain Attrition to persist beyond a scene, instead of converting normally into Settled Fatigue.

If a character has persistent Attrition from a specific rule, a Full Rest reduces that Attrition by an amount equal to:

$2 \times \text{Endurance}$

If no persistent Attrition exists, this step does not apply.

3. WOUND TREATMENT

During a Full Rest, a creature can receive Medicine treatment to free Wound Slots.

Treatment does not happen just because 8 hours pass. The Wound must be stabilized and someone must treat the Zone with appropriate tools.

If the treatment succeeds, the patient frees **1** Wound Slot from that Zone.

REST	CAN STABILIZE	CAN TREAT	CAN FREE SLOTS
15 minutes	Not by base rule	No	0
30 minutes	Light Wound	No	0
60 minutes	Severe Wound	No	0
Full Rest	Critical Wound or any stabilized Wound	Yes, with Medicine	1 slot per treated character

The full rules for difficulty, kits, and adjustment by occupied slots are in **Wounds and Damage**.

This section only defines what each rest duration permits.

4. EQUIPMENT REPAIR

During a Full Rest, a character can attempt to repair damaged equipment.

If they succeed at the appropriate roll based on the required specialization and the item's grade, they recover up to 5 Durability points on each relevant piece.

This can apply to:

- weapons
- armor
- shields
- tools
- special equipment that allows repair

The Narrator determines which specialization applies according to the object.

5. AFFLICTION PROGRESSION OR RELIEF

Each day of Full Rest reduces the intensity of each active Affliction by 1, unless a specific rule says otherwise.

This represents that certain consequences require time, care, and real recovery before they begin to ease.

An Affliction does not necessarily disappear after one night of sleep. This effect reduces its intensity according to the Affliction rules.

6. DAY PREPARATION

During a Full Rest, the group can reorganize for what comes next.

The group may:

- review maps and notes
- discuss the route ahead
- reorganize provisions
- prepare tools
- exchange information about threats
- decide priorities
- reinforce bonds
- address narrative tensions

This moment does not only recover resources. It also lets the group decide how they will continue.

ON PHYSICAL RECOVERY

A Full Rest does not automatically remove a Severe Wound, fracture, mutilation, or persistent condition.

It restores an important part of the character's functionality, but it does not replace stabilization, treatment, Medicine, or prolonged healing when those are necessary.

Sleeping well can return your margin. It cannot always return your integrity.

RISKS OF RESTING

Resting is not always safe.

Recovery is a general rule. Risk depends on the fiction of the scene.

Stopping can mean:

- being found
- losing position

- suffering an environmental shift
- being exposed to nearby threats
- giving the situation time to worsen
- allowing an enemy to reorganize

When the group rests in an unsafe, uncertain, or actively hostile location, the Narrator may make a secret roll to determine whether an unexpected event occurs.

WHEN TO ROLL RISK

The risk roll should not be made by habit. It should be used when resting genuinely exposes the group to consequences.

This includes situations such as:

- hostile territory
- active pursuit
- likely presence of predators or enemies
- severe weather
- unstable or unknown areas
- resting near an active threat
- scenes where stopping has clear narrative consequences

If the group rests in a safe, controlled, or well-protected shelter, the Narrator may skip the roll.

BASE RISK BY DURATION

When a risk roll is appropriate, the Narrator rolls 1d100 in secret and applies the modifier for the rest's duration.

DURATION	BASE MODIFIER
15 minutes	+0
30 minutes	+10
60 minutes	+20
Full Rest	+30

The Narrator may apply additional modifiers according to the situation.

SITUATION	MODIFIER
Safe shelter	-20
Organized watch	-10
Bad weather	+10
Hostile territory	+10
Active pursuit	+20
Nearby enemies	+20
Hidden or hard-to-track location	-10

These modifiers are not mandatory or exclusive. They help the risk depend on the world, not only the clock.

UNEXPECTED EVENTS

If the Narrator determines the rest is subject to risk, consult the following table after the secret roll.

IDI00	EVENT	DESCRIPTION
1–45	No incidents	The rest passes without interruption and the group can recover normally.
46–55	Unsettling sign	The group detects recent tracks, distant sounds, a strange smell, or signs of nearby activity. There is no immediate interruption, but tension rises.
56–65	Environmental shift	Weather worsens, visibility drops, temperature changes, or the terrain becomes more difficult. The rest is completed, but the overall situation worsens.
66–75	Discomfort or displacement	The location proves less safe than expected: moisture, small collapses, aggressive frost, noises, or discomfort force the group to move or interrupt part of the rest.
76–85	Lost position or bearing	The group is forced to change location, loses orientation, or must spend additional time regaining a safe position or reliable route.
86–93	Hostile interruption	A creature, enemy scout, or environmental threat interrupts the rest. It may not immediately become combat, but it forces the group to react.
94–100	Dire event	A serious complication occurs: ambush, dangerous revelation, betrayal, environmental collapse, or a narrative turn that severely alters the situation.

The unexpected event roll is always secret and made by the Narrator.

QUICK SUMMARY

REST	RECOVERY	TASKS	BASE RISK
15 minutes	-1 Fatigue from one character	1 brief task	+0
30 minutes	-1 Fatigue from each resting character	1 significant task	+10
60 minutes	-2 Fatigue from each resting character	Up to 2 tasks	+20
Full Rest	-3 Fatigue from each resting character	Treatment, repair, and broad preparation	+30 if the location is unsafe

The first Short Rest after a significant scene reduces Fatigue normally. Later Short Rests before another significant scene do not reduce Fatigue again unless a specific rule allows it.

EXAMPLE

The group attempts a 30-minute Short Rest inside abandoned ruins. They know enemy scouts are nearby.

The Narrator decides the rest is possible, but risky. They roll 1d100 in secret and apply modifiers for hostile territory and nearby enemies.

The rest may be completed, but the result can produce an unsettling sign, an environmental shift, lost position, or hostile interruption.

Rest is recovery time. It is not immunity from consequence.

WOUNDS AND DAMAGE

Wounds define what happens when an attack surpasses defense and reaches the target's body, equipment, or structure.

They do not replace the Attack Roll or the Impact Roll. They enter afterward, once effective contact exists and the scene needs to determine what consequence the hit leaves behind.

Transcendence uses two damage models:

CASE	MODEL USED
PC against NPC, creature, monster, or adversary	The target's damage model
NPC against PC	Localized Wounds by zone

This separation allows enemies to use HP, zones, phases, breakable parts, or vital points of their own, while player characters do not depend on a general life bar.

A hit against a player character leaves a physical mark. That mark occupies slots, limits function, and can saturate or collapse a zone.

ATTACK FLOW

A physical attack follows this sequence:

1. The attacker declares the attack.
2. Determine the target or zone, if applicable.
3. Resolve the Attack Roll against the target's Defense Roll.
4. If the Attack Roll does not beat the Defense Roll, the attack does not connect effectively.
5. If the attack connects, the attacker makes the Impact Roll.
6. Determine the applicable Block.
7. Convert the result into damage, Wound, break, or effect according to the target's model.

The Impact Roll is not made if the attack does not find an opening.

Defense decides whether the hit connects. Block decides how much of that pressure actually reaches the body, piece, or part struck.

IMPACT ROLL

The Impact Roll measures the pressure transmitted by the attack after it surpasses defense.

$$\text{Impact} = (\text{Competency Rank} \times \text{Weapon Damage}) + (\text{Associated Characteristic} \times \text{Weapon Grade})$$

Impact is not only raw force. It also includes mass, angle, execution, weapon quality, contact point, and the attacker’s ability to turn an opening into consequence.

CRITICAL IMPACT

A **Critical Impact** occurs when the designated critical die of the Impact Roll shows its maximum value.

If the Impact Roll uses multiple dice, the attacker must designate one before rolling. At the table, using a die of a different color is recommended. In digital play, the die can be marked with an equivalent label.

Only that die validates Critical Impact. The other dice add Impact normally.

IMPACT DIE	CRITICAL RESULT
d4	4
d6	6
d8	8
d10	10
d12	12

Weapons with smaller dice generate criticals more often. Weapons with larger dice generate criticals less often, but usually transmit more Impact.

Increasing rank raises total Impact, but does not increase critical chance by itself, because only the designated die can validate it.

A Critical Impact can allow the attacker to:

- apply critical damage against an NPC if its model defines it
- attempt to break a part, equipment piece, or protection
- trigger a Technique that requires Critical Impact
- apply a physical consequence if the attack or target declares it

Critical Impact does not grant a universal list of effects. The weapon, Technique, target, or scene defines which options are available.

CRITICAL POTENCY

Critical Potency measures the weapon's ability to break, deform, open, or disable a resistant structure during a Critical Impact.

$$\text{Critical Potency} = \text{Base Potency} \times \text{Weapon Potency Multiplier}$$

If the result produces fractions or decimals, round up unless a specific rule says otherwise.

Base Potency comes from the weapon's material, construction, or profile. The multiplier depends on weapon type and expresses how that weapon transmits force during a critical.

WEAPON TYPE	MULTIPLIER	IDEAL USE
Spears	80%	Piercing small points and light protections
Axes	120%	Opening material and splitting rigid surfaces
Maces	150%	Breaking heavy armor and crushing resistant structures
Long blades	100%	Broad cuts against medium-resistance surfaces
Daggers	50%	Frequent criticals against vulnerable or unprotected zones
Short blades	75%	Fast attacks with moderate potency
Thrown weapons	40%	Precise ranged impacts with low structural break power
Ranged weapons	60%	Puncture or impact from range
Flexible weapons	30%	Control, restraint, and imbalance

Material does not necessarily change a weapon's damage die. An iron khopesh and an adamantium khopesh may use the same base damage. The difference appears in Potency and Durability: the first may cut the same way, but the second breaks better and resists longer.

BREAKING PARTS

Breaking Parts is a strategic option available when an attack produces Critical Impact and a breakable target has been declared.

The target must be something the attack can plausibly reach and affect:

- weapon
- shield

- armor piece
- limb
- jaw
- horn
- shell
- tail
- wing
- joint
- vital point
- destructible part defined by the encounter

To resolve the break, compare Critical Potency against Durability.

Critical Potency $\geq$ Target Durability

COMPARISON	RESULT
Critical Potency $\geq$ Durability	The part breaks, is disabled, or becomes unusable
Critical Potency $<$ Durability	The part does not break and loses 1 Durability

Durability loss only occurs during a valid break attempt:

- through Critical Impact
- through a Technique that permits breaking without a critical
- through a specific attack rule

Normal attacks do not reduce Durability by default.

If a broken piece contributed Block, it stops contributing Block until repaired or replaced. Durability loss does not reduce Block by itself; the piece functions until it breaks, unless a rule says otherwise.

Breaking a part can:

- disable an attack option
- reduce defense
- destroy equipment
- prevent a dependent Technique
- reduce mobility
- alter a behavior pattern

- open a vulnerable point
- change an encounter phase

BLOCK

When a hit connects against a protected zone, that zone contributes **Block**.

$$\text{Block} = \text{BB} + \text{MB} + \text{DC} + \text{PQ}$$

COMPONENT	MEANING
BB	Base Block by armor category
MB	Material Bonus
DC	Defensive Competency with the armor in the zone
PQ	Piece quality or grade

ARMOR	BB
Light	2
Medium	4
Heavy	6

$$\text{MB} = \text{floor}(\text{Durability} / 5)$$

Defensive Competency equals the competency level in the armor type protecting the struck zone.

It only applies if that armor actually participates in absorbing the Impact.

An unarmored zone does not contribute armor Block.

WOUND THRESHOLD

To convert Impact into a Wound against player characters, use the zone's **Wound Threshold**.

$$\text{Wound Threshold} = \max(\text{Block}, 1)$$

This minimum prevents an unarmored zone from turning any hit into an automatic Critical Wound.

Block still functions as normal protection. Wound Threshold only determines the severity of the Wound once the attack has connected.

PLAYERS AGAINST NPCs

When a player character strikes an NPC, creature, monster, or adversary, the attack uses the target's damage model.

$$\text{Effective Damage} = \text{Impact} - \text{Target Block}$$

If the result is lower than 0, treat it as 0.

That damage applies to the HP, reserve, zone, vital point, phase, or subsystem the enemy defines.

A common enemy may use simple HP. An important creature may have zones with their own values. A champion may use vital points, breakable parts, and phases that change when a structure falls.

Critical Impact resolves against that model. Not every enemy needs breakable parts, but enemies that have them must state what happens when a part breaks.

NPCs AGAINST PLAYERS

When an NPC strikes a player character, general HP is not used. The hit is recorded as a Wound in the struck zone.

Resolve in this order:

1. Determine the struck zone.
2. Identify the armor in that zone.
3. Resolve the Defense Roll using applicable Evasion and applicable Agility according to the armor in that zone.
4. If the attack connects, roll Impact.

5. Calculate the zone's Block.
6. Calculate the Wound Threshold.
7. Compare Impact against the Wound Threshold.
8. Record the Wound if applicable.

RELATION	RESULT	SLOTS
Impact $\leq$ Wound Threshold	No Wound	0
Impact $>$ Wound Threshold and $\leq 2 \times$ Wound Threshold	Light Wound	1
Impact $> 2 \times$ Wound Threshold and $\leq 3 \times$ Wound Threshold	Severe Wound	2
Impact $> 3 \times$ Wound Threshold	Critical Wound	3

A Critical Wound does not force a Resistance Roll by default. It already occupies 3 slots and can saturate or collapse a zone by itself.

A Resistance Roll is only forced if:

- the Critical Wound causes Collapse in a vital zone, such as Head or Torso
- the attack, NPC, or Technique says so
- the associated Ailment requires a Resistance Roll
- the Narrator declares it due to an extreme scene circumstance

The Resistance Roll used by vital Collapse is an Alteration Resistance Roll. It represents bodily shock, functional loss, internal trauma, or physical interruption of the body.

WOUND SLOTS

Each character zone has a number of Wound Slots.

ZONE	SLOTS
Head	3
Torso	5
Arms	4
Legs	4
Feet	3

A Wound always attempts to occupy its full slots in the struck zone.

If the zone has enough free slots, mark them normally.

If it does not have enough free slots, mark the remaining slots and the excess produces **Overflow**.

ZONE STATE	CONDITION	EFFECT
Functional	The zone has at least 1 free slot	Applies no zone penalty by itself
Saturated	The zone reached its slot maximum exactly	Applies Saturation Penalty
Collapsed	A Wound did not fit fully, or a Saturated zone received another Wound	Applies that zone's Collapse effect

EXAMPLE

A character has Torso at 4 of 5 occupied slots.

They receive a Severe Wound to the Torso, which should occupy 2 slots.

Only 1 slot remains free, so that slot is marked and the other produces Overflow.

The Torso becomes Collapsed.

SATURATION PENALTY

When a zone is Saturated, its base penalty equals the number of occupied slots in that zone.

Saturation Penalty = occupied slots in the zone

SATURATED ZONE	BASE PENALTY
Head	-3
Torso	-5
Arms	-4
Legs	-4
Feet	-3

This penalty only applies to rolls and actions that clearly depend on that zone.

It is not a universal character penalty.

SATURATION AND COLLAPSE BY ZONE

ZONE	SATURATED	COLLAPSED
Head	Saturation Penalty to mental Specialization Rolls and visual or auditory perception. Saturation Penalty to Preparation.	Applies Stunned. The character must pass an Alteration Resistance Roll against the severity of the Wound that caused Collapse or become Unconscious.
Torso	Saturation Penalty to Tolerance, demanding physical actions, heavy defenses, holding posture under Impact, and Techniques that strain the torso.	The character becomes Incapacitated until stabilized. If the Wound that caused Collapse was Critical, they also enter Agony.
Arms	Saturation Penalty to Attack Rolls, Impact Rolls, and physical Specialization Rolls that depend on arms, grip, shield, weapons, or manipulation.	One arm, grip, or execution line becomes unusable. The character cannot use two-handed weapons, shields, or limb-dependent Techniques if they rely on the collapsed part. May apply Impeded.
Legs	Movement is halved. Saturation Penalty to Strength or Tenacity physical Specialization Rolls that depend on legs.	The character cannot walk functionally without support or help. They cannot charge, run, or jump.
Feet	The character cannot sprint. Saturation Penalty to Agility physical Specialization Rolls that depend on fine footing.	The character can move only with support, help, or an appropriate Specialization Roll. If they try to move under pressure without support and fail, they become Knocked Down.

The suggested difficulty for the Resistance Roll caused by Collapse depends on the Wound that produced Overflow.

WOUND THAT CAUSED COLLAPSE	DIFFICULTY
Light	Challenging
Severe	Rigorous
Critical	Demanding

BODY STATES

Body States describe a creature's general condition once damage is no longer only local.

STATE	MEANING
Operational	Can act with any penalties from zone, Ailment, Fatigue, or Attrition
Incapacitated	Cannot perform meaningful actions. May speak, crawl, hold something, or react weakly if the fiction permits
Unconscious	Cannot act or perceive usefully. Cannot defend actively
Agony	At risk of dying without stabilization. Cannot act meaningfully
Dead	The creature cannot be recovered by normal scene-level means

If a zone that is already Collapsed receives another Wound, apply or refresh the zone's Collapse effect.

If the zone is Head or Torso, the character must pass an Alteration Resistance Roll against the severity of the new Wound.

If they fail:

- Head escalates toward Unconscious
- Torso escalates toward Agony

If a character in Agony receives another Critical Wound to Head or Torso, they die unless a specific rule, Technique, immediate intervention, or table decision establishes another outcome.

ZONES AND LOCATION

For NPC attacks against player characters, location is determined before resolving defense. This prevents the Narrator from always choosing the most damaged zone.

ID100	ZONE
01–04	Head
05–10	Feet
11–45	Torso
46–65	Arms
66–100	Legs

Player attacks against NPCs do not use this table by default. The player declares target, intent, Technique, or vulnerable point according to what the scene and available information allow.

STABILIZE, TREAT, AND HEAL

Transcendence separates three recovery steps.

STEP	FUNCTION	FREES SLOTS
Stabilize	Stops immediate deterioration, active shock, open bleeding, or Collapse that keeps worsening	No
Treat	Cares for a zone during a Full Rest to prepare recovery	Not by itself
Heal	Frees occupied slots through Full Rest with successful treatment	Yes

Medicine covers stabilization, treatment, and healing of bodily damage.

Herbalism, alchemy, objects, Techniques, and artifacts may modify these rules from their own sections.

STABILIZATION

To stabilize a Wound, a character makes a Medicine Specialization Roll with Wisdom.

WOUND	DIFFICULTY	REQUIRED KIT	TIME
Light	Challenging	Basic	30 minutes
Severe	Rigorous	Advanced	60 minutes
Critical	Demanding	Specialized	Full Rest

On success, the Wound is stabilized. Its immediate effects stop worsening.

On failure, the Wound remains active and the attempt may consume time, resources, or create a complication if the scene remains under pressure.

TREATMENT AND HEALING

Wounds must be stabilized before slots can be freed. An active Wound must be stabilized first.

REST	CAN STABILIZE	CAN TREAT	CAN FREE SLOTS
30 minutes	Light Wound	No	0
60 minutes	Severe Wound	No	0
Full Rest	Critical Wound or any stabilized Wound	Yes, with Medicine	1 slot per treated character

When treating a zone during a Full Rest, the character caring for the patient makes a Medicine Specialization Roll with Wisdom.

The base difficulty and required kit depend on the most severe slot still occupied in that zone.

MOST SEVERE OCCUPIED SLOT	DIFFICULTY	REQUIRED KIT
Light	Challenging	Basic
Severe	Rigorous	Advanced
Critical	Demanding	Specialized

Then increase the Reference Level according to how many slots are occupied in the same zone at the start of the Full Rest.

OCCUPIED SLOTS IN THE ZONE	ADJUSTMENT
1	No adjustment
2–3	+1 Reference Level
4–5	+2 Reference Level
Collapsed zone	+1 additional Reference Level

On success, the patient frees 1 occupied slot from that zone.

The freed slot must belong to a stabilized Wound.

On failure, the zone frees no slots.

When several stabilized Wounds exist in the same zone, the treating character declares which slot they are trying to free before rolling.

The Narrator may require the most severe Wound to be reduced first if that injury maintains Agony, Collapse, or dominant functional loss.

PROGRESSION EXAMPLES

A Light Wound occupies 1 slot. If it is stabilized and receives successful treatment during a Full Rest, it frees that slot and disappears.

A Severe Wound occupies 2 slots. After a Full Rest with successful treatment, it frees 1 slot and becomes a Light Wound. It needs another Full Rest with successful treatment to disappear.

A Critical Wound occupies 3 slots. After a Full Rest with successful treatment, it frees 1 slot and becomes Severe. After another Full Rest with successful treatment, it becomes Light. After another, it disappears.

CREATURE PARTS AND ENEMIES

Enemies do not need to use the same anatomical zones as a player character. An important creature uses the zones its anatomy and encounter design require.

By default, an important creature should be organized into five major locations for table readability.

These locations may be:

- skull
- jaw
- torso
- legs
- tail
- core
- dorsal plates
- limbs
- wings
- any equivalent distribution

Each creature part can have:

FIELD	USE
Defense Roll	Defense or difficulty to strike that part
HP	Normal damage reserve for the part
Block	Impact reduction while the part remains functional
Potency	Offensive or structural capacity if that part attacks or breaks
Durability	Resistance of the part against breaking
Linked abilities	Attacks, Techniques, traits, or phases that depend on the part

Breaking a creature part limits enemy options.

If an ice wolf has Frost Breath linked to its jaw, breaking the jaw prevents that ability until the enemy stat block says otherwise.

Resource extraction rules are resolved in their own section. Here, only three questions matter:

- whether the part remains functional
- whether it provides Block
- which enemy options remain available

CRITICAL IMPACT AND BREAKING PARTS

Critical Impact defines when a hit found an exceptional opening.

Breaking Parts defines what that hit can do to a concrete structure: an armor piece, shield, weapon, jaw, natural plate, or any part the encounter has made relevant.

This system does not turn every critical into automatic extra damage. It separates three questions:

1. Did the hit produce Critical Impact?
2. Is there a valid breakable target?
3. Does Critical Potency overcome the target's Durability?

A critical opens an opportunity. Breaking determines whether that opportunity changes the target's structure.

CRITICAL IMPACT

A **Critical Impact** occurs when the designated critical die of the Impact Roll shows its maximum value.

When an Impact Roll uses multiple dice, the attacker designates one die before rolling.

At the table, using a die of a different color is recommended. In digital play, the die may be marked with an equivalent label.

Only that die can validate Critical Impact.

IMPACT DIE	CRITICAL RESULT
d4	4
d6	6
d8	8
d10	10
d12	12

The other dice in the Impact Roll add damage or pressure normally. They do not validate a critical by themselves, even if they show their maximum value.

EXAMPLE: DESIGNATED CRITICAL DIE

A character rolls **3d8** for Impact.

Before rolling, they declare the red die as the critical die.

If the red die shows **8**, Critical Impact occurs.

If the other two dice show **8** and the red die does not, their values still increase Impact, but no Critical Impact occurs.

WHAT CRITICAL IMPACT ALLOWS

Critical Impact grants access to critical options defined by the weapon, Technique, target, or encounter.

By default, it can allow:

- attempting to Break Parts against a declared breakable target
- applying critical damage if the NPC model defines it
- triggering a Technique that requires Critical Impact
- applying a physical consequence if the attack, part, or target declares it

Critical Impact does not force a Critical Wound against player characters by itself.

Wound severity still depends on the relation between Impact and Wound Threshold, unless a specific rule increases that severity.

DECLARING A BREAKABLE TARGET

To attempt Breaking Parts, the attacker must declare a breakable target.

The declaration happens before resolving the break. Some Techniques may require the breakable target to be declared before the Attack Roll or before the Impact Roll.

A breakable target must meet three conditions:

1. The attack can reach it.
2. The surface can be broken, disabled, or rendered unusable by that type of force.
3. The scene, creature, equipment, or Technique recognizes that part as relevant.

Valid targets can include:

- weapon
- shield
- armor piece
- held or carried object
- jaw
- horn
- shell
- wing
- tail
- limb
- joint
- natural plate
- vital point
- destructible part defined by the encounter

Ordinary soft tissue is not treated as a breakable structure by default.

It can be the target of damage, Wound, or Ailment, but not of Breaking Parts unless the creature defines that zone as a structure, vital point, or destructible part.

CRITICAL POTENCY

Critical Potency measures whether the hit can break the declared structure.

$$\text{Critical Potency} = \text{Base Potency} \times \text{Potency Multiplier}$$

Base Potency comes from the weapon's material, construction, or profile.

The Potency Multiplier comes from the weapon type.

If the result produces fractions or decimals, round up unless a specific rule says otherwise.

WEAPON TYPE	MULTIPLIER	BREAK READING
Spears	80%	Focused point pressure. Better against openings than rigid mass.
Axes	120%	Heavy cutting that opens material and compromises resistant edges.
Maces	150%	Blunt impact against armor, bone, plate, and hard structure.
Long blades	100%	Balance between broad cutting and stable force transfer.
Daggers	50%	High precision, low break power against resistant structures.
Short blades	75%	Fast cutting with moderate break power.
Thrown weapons	40%	Precise contact, little mass for sustained breaking.
Ranged weapons	60%	Puncture or impact at range with limited break power.
Flexible weapons	30%	Control and imbalance more than direct material destruction.

Concrete Base Potency values belong to the weapon, material, and creature-part catalogs.

This section defines how those values are used, not what Potency each material has.

RESOLVING THE BREAK

When a valid break attempt exists, compare Critical Potency against Durability.

Critical Potency $\geq$ Target Durability

COMPARISON	RESULT
Critical Potency $\geq$ Durability	The target breaks, is disabled, or becomes unusable.
Critical Potency $<$ Durability	The target does not break and loses <u>1</u> Durability.

Durability loss only occurs during a valid break attempt.

A valid attempt can come from:

- Critical Impact against a declared breakable target
- a Technique that permits breaking without Critical Impact
- a Technique that expands the break-validation range
- a specific weapon, creature, object, or scene rule

A normal attack does not reduce Durability by default.

EXAMPLE: FAILED BREAK

An attacker produces Critical Impact and tries to break a shield with Durability 9.

Their final Critical Potency is 7.

The shield does not break, but loses 1 Durability and falls to 8.

Its Block does not change from that loss. The shield keeps functioning until it breaks.

BROKEN EQUIPMENT

A broken equipment piece stops providing the function that depended on its integrity.

If armor, shield, or protection contributed Block, it stops contributing that Block until repaired or replaced.

If a weapon breaks, it cannot be used for normal attacks or Techniques requiring that weapon, unless a rule permits using it while damaged.

Durability loss does not reduce Block gradually.

The piece functions until it breaks. This avoids recalculating smaller values after every hit and keeps the table focused on the moment of rupture.

BREAKING AND THE CURRENT HIT

By default, breaking a piece does not retroactively remove the Block, defense, or effect that piece already contributed to the hit currently being resolved.

The break affects the piece's state from that moment forward.

A Technique, weapon, creature rule, or specific effect may say otherwise. If it does, it must clearly state that the break affects the current Impact, ignores current Block, or modifies the resolution in progress.

CREATURE PARTS

A creature part can have:

- Defense Roll
- HP
- Block
- Potency
- Durability
- linked abilities

Breaking a part does not only reduce numbers. It changes what the creature can do.

A broken jaw can prevent a breath attack. A broken wing can prevent flight. A broken plate can open a vulnerable point. A broken horn can end a command signal.

The enemy stat block must state:

- which parts exist
- what values they have
- which abilities depend on them
- what happens when a part breaks

Important creatures should be organized into five major locations so the table can read them without getting lost in excessive anatomy.

EXAMPLE: CREATURE PART

An ice wolf has **Jaw** as a breakable part.

That part has its own Durability and supports the **Frost Breath** ability.

If the characters break the Jaw, the wolf cannot use **Frost Breath** while that part remains broken, even if the rest of the creature still has HP.

TECHNIQUES AND BREAKING

Techniques can modify the normal relation between criticals and breaking.

A Technique can:

- allow a break attempt without Critical Impact
- expand the critical die results that validate breaking
- increase Critical Potency
- ignore part of Durability
- declare a part as breakable when it normally would not be
- apply an additional consequence if the break occurs
- make the break affect the current hit

A Technique must state exactly which of these things it allows.

If it only increases damage, it does not allow breaking by itself.

If it only expands break validation, it does not increase Critical Potency.

If it declares a new part as a target, there must still be a credible way to reach it.

RESOLUTION ORDER

When an attack can generate a break, use this order:

1. Declare the attack and normal target.
2. Declare the breakable target if the rule or Technique requires it.
3. Resolve Attack Roll against Defense Roll.
4. If the attack fails, no break occurs.
5. If the attack connects, make the Impact Roll.
6. Check whether the designated critical die validates Critical Impact, or whether a Technique permits breaking another way.
7. Calculate Critical Potency.
8. Compare Critical Potency against Durability.
9. Apply break or 1 Durability loss.
10. Resolve damage, Wound, HP, phase change, or additional consequence according to the target.

If a rule changes this order, it must say so.

A reactive Technique, trap, creature, or boss part can insert its own steps, but the table must always know when the breakable target was declared and when the break is validated.

LIMITS

An attack does not break anything just because it was critical.

The target must be:

- reachable
- materially affectable
- relevant to the scene

A light weapon may find criticals often, but fail against high Durability.

A heavy weapon may break hard structures, but not perform the fine work of a dagger.

Weapon choice matters because breaking does not measure the same surface as damage.

Resource extraction rules are not resolved here. If a broken part loses value as material, trophy, or sample, that is defined in the extraction section.

QUICK SUMMARY

ELEMENT	RULE
Critical Impact	Occurs if the designated critical die shows its maximum value.
Multiple Impact dice	Only the designated die validates critical.
Breaking Parts	Requires Critical Impact or a rule that permits breaking.
Breakable target	Must be reachable, affectable, and relevant.
Successful break	Critical Potency $\geq$ Durability.
Failed break	The target loses <u>1</u> Durability.
Normal attacks	Do not reduce Durability by default.
Broken equipment	Loses the function that depended on its integrity.
Block	Does not decrease gradually from Durability loss.
Current hit	Breaking does not retroactively remove Block or defense unless a specific rule says so.

COVER, VISIBILITY, AND CONCEALMENT

Cover, Visibility, and Concealment resolve three separate layers of a scene.

LAYER	WHAT IT RESOLVES
Cover	Whether something physical blocks, deflects, or absorbs an attack line
Visibility	How far and how clearly details can be distinguished
Concealment	Whether a creature is precisely located by an enemy

These layers are resolved separately.

A creature can have Cover without being concealed. It can stand in dense fog without anything stopping a hit. It can be concealed behind a barrier even when the area is well lit.

COVER

Cover is physical or structural protection that interferes with an attack line.

Fog, smoke, darkness, dust, or rain are not Cover by themselves. They reduce Visibility and can help a creature hide, but they do not stop a hit.

COVER	CRITERION	EFFECT
Light Cover	Protects a smaller part of the body or partially interferes with the attack line	-1 to the attacker's Attack Roll
Medium Cover	Protects a significant part of the body, but leaves clear openings	-3 to the attacker's Attack Roll
Total Cover	No direct attack line to the target	The target cannot be chosen by direct attacks

LIGHT COVER

The target is not fully exposed, but can still be attacked through a reasonable line.

Examples:

- low furniture
- railing
- small rock
- thin tree
- door edge
- cover protecting about a quarter of the body

MEDIUM COVER

The target is protected by a significant obstacle, but still has some exposure.

Examples:

- thick tree
- large rock
- barricade
- window
- opening
- wall corner
- cover protecting half the body or more without covering it completely

TOTAL COVER

The obstacle completely blocks the direct line to the target.

Examples:

- solid wall
- closed door
- trench with no exposure
- closed structure
- mass that fully covers the target

A target with Total Cover cannot be chosen by direct attacks.

Even so, it may still be affected by:

- area attacks
- Techniques that alter the attack route
- destruction of the obstacle
- flanking
- elevation
- ricochet
- explosion
- any fiction that bypasses the direct line

DESTROYING COVER

Physical Cover can be destroyed if the object producing it has material, Potency, and Durability.

To break Cover, use the normal breaking rule.

Critical Potency >= Object Durability

RESULT	EFFECT
Critical Potency >= Durability	The Cover breaks, opens, or stops protecting according to its nature
Critical Potency < Durability	The Cover does not break and loses <u>1</u> Durability

Durability loss only occurs during a valid break attempt.

A valid attempt can come from:

- Critical Impact
- a Technique that permits breaking
- a specific weapon, object, or scene rule

Normal attacks do not reduce Durability by default.

COVER AND ATTACK TYPES

Cover applies against melee attacks, ranged attacks, and projectiles whenever the object materially interrupts the attack line.

If the attacker moves to an angle where the Cover no longer blocks the line, the Cover stops applying.

Cover is geometric and material. It is not a fixed state attached to the character.

SHIELDS AS COVER

Shields are the main source of portable Cover.

A shield primarily grants Cover to its carrier's space.

Covering another creature normally requires:

- a Technique
- a shield Reaction
- a rule that allows that Cover to extend outside the user's own space

Cover granted by a shield depends on:

- shield size
 - carrier size
 - covered creature size
 - attack angle
 - the carrier's ability to carry and control the shield
-

COVER AND AREAS

Against area attacks, Cover only helps if the object can stand between the creature and the effect's origin, direction, or expansion.

SITUATION	EFFECT
Cover clearly blocks the area	Apply normal Cover
Cover partially protects against the area	Apply half the Cover penalty, rounded down
The area surrounds, fills, or ignores the Cover	Cover does not apply

A barricade can help against a frontal explosion.

It does not help against gas filling the entire zone or fire falling from above.

VISIBILITY

Visibility defines how far and how clearly a creature can distinguish visual details.

For grid measurement:

1 meter = 1 square

The game can use a grid or flexible measurement. A grid is recommended when combat, areas, Cover, approximate position, or tactical movement matter.

STANDARD VISUAL RANGE

In clear conditions, a creature can recognize relevant details up to `60 meters` .

Beyond that range, an action depending on visual detail requires a Perception Specialization Roll.

The Narrator increases difficulty according to:

- distance
- size
- movement
- contrast
- environmental conditions

Simple rule:

`+1 Reference Level per 10 meters beyond effective visual range`

Do not use 2-meter increments. They create too much counting at the table and do not add useful decisions.

REDUCED VISIBILITY RANGES

CONDITION	INTENSITY	EFFECTIVE VISUAL RANGE
Rain	Light	24 m
Rain	Intense	15 m
Rain	Storm	8 m
Snow	Light	24 m
Snow	Intense	15 m
Snow	Snowstorm	8 m
Fog	Light	20 m
Fog	Dense	10 m
Fog	Thick	5 m
Smoke	Light	20 m
Smoke	Dense	5 m
Smoke	Choking	2 m
Dust or sand	Light	25 m
Dust or sand	Moderate	12 m
Dust or sand	Storm	5 m
Absolute darkness	No light source	0 m
Extranatural darkness	Active	0 m, unless a valid countermeasure applies

These values are reference guides.

If the condition is already represented as a Moderate, Severe, Disastrous, or Extreme environment, use environmental severity as the primary authority.

LIGHT SOURCES

Light sources establish an effective visual range when the environment lacks sufficient illumination.

SOURCE	CLEAR RANGE	IN DENSE VISUAL CONDITION
Candle	2 m	1 m
Torch	4 m	2 m
Oil lamp	6 m	3 m

A light source does not remove smoke, fog, dust, or extranatural darkness by itself.

It only allows vision within the range it can still pierce.

ABSOLUTE DARKNESS AND EXTRANATURAL DARKNESS

Absolute darkness occurs when there is not enough natural, artificial, or reflected light to see. In these conditions, visual range is 0 m.

Extranatural darkness also reduces visual range to 0 m, but it is not solved by an ordinary light source.

Extranatural darkness tied to the Darkness element blocks natural light and common illumination.

Countering it requires a compatible source:

- extranatural light tied to the Light element
 - artifact
 - Technique
 - opposing environmental condition
 - specific rule
-

PERCEPTION AND SENSES

Perception does not mean sight alone.

It represents the ability to locate, distinguish, or interpret sensory signals.

A character can use Perception to:

- see
- hear

- smell
- feel vibration
- recognize contact
- read chemical signals
- use echolocation
- interpret another special sense they possess

Special senses use the same Perception structure unless a rule says otherwise.

A creature with a special sense may have additional bonuses and is not blocked by effects that do not interfere with that sense.

Example: a creature tracking by smell can ignore visual Darkness to locate a target, but may suffer penalties from wind, water, chemical smoke, or a Technique that alters scent.

COMBAT WITHOUT VISION

A creature that cannot see its target does not automatically lose all competencies.

Instead:

- it cannot precisely choose targets it has not located
- it cannot use Techniques requiring clear visual reading
- it can attack an approximate position with a penalty or increased difficulty
- it may defend worse against threats it cannot read
- it can use other senses if they are relevant

SITUATION	EFFECT
Target located by any relevant sense	Can be targeted; apply penalty or Reference Level increase only if the signal is weak, indirect, or hard to interpret
Target not located	Cannot be targeted by a direct attack

The Impact Roll does not lose all bonuses from lack of sight.

If the attack connects, Impact resolves normally unless a specific rule says otherwise.

CONCEALMENT

Concealment is a tactical state: a creature is not precisely located by one or more enemies.

It is not invisibility. It is not immunity. It does not erase physical evidence.

It means the enemy does not know exactly where the creature is or cannot fix it as a direct target.

Concealment is tracked by enemy or enemy group. A creature can be hidden from one guard, but not from another who saw them enter.

HIDE

Hide is a base action when performed under pressure.

ACTION	RHYTHM	ATTRITION	ROLL
Hide	5	1	Appropriate Specialization Roll against environmental difficulty or enemy Perception

Outside a hostile scene, Hide has no rhythm cost.

The Narrator only calls for the roll when risk, opposition, or consequence exists.

A creature can attempt to hide if at least one of these conditions is true:

- it has Medium Cover or Total Cover
- it is outside the effective visual range of relevant enemies
- it is inside a reduced-Visibility condition that can hide its position
- it has a Technique, trait, artifact, or preparation that permits Concealment

In addition, no relevant enemy must have it clearly located by an applicable sense.

Wanting to vanish is not enough while someone clearly sees, hears, smells, or perceives it.

If an enemy has it located without obstruction, the creature must first create a real opportunity.

It can do this by:

- breaking line of sight
 - entering Cover
 - entering smoke, fog, Darkness, vegetation, a crowd, or sufficient noise
 - using a distraction
 - moving outside the effective range of the sense locating it
 - using a Technique, trait, artifact, or preparation that permits hiding while observed
-

CONCEALMENT ROLL

The creature makes an appropriate Specialization Roll against environmental difficulty or enemy Perception, depending on the scene.

Typical specializations:

- **Stealth**, to hide through silence, body control, and position
- **Survival**, to hide in natural terrain, vegetation, weather, or tracks
- another specialization, if a trait, Technique, or artifact justifies it

Ties favor the concealed creature.

EFFECTS OF CONCEALMENT

While a creature is concealed from an enemy:

- that enemy cannot choose it as the target of direct “one creature” attacks
- that enemy can attack an area or suspected position if it has a reason to do so
- that enemy can search with Perception, a Technique, or a scene-specific action
- that enemy can react to obvious signals, noise, contact, or environmental changes

Concealment does not protect against area effects that cover the real position.

ATTACKING FROM CONCEALMENT

Attacking from Concealment can grant an opening advantage if the target does not react in time.

Before resolving the attack, relevant creatures within **10 meters** can attempt to detect the action if they have an applicable sense.

Use a Perception Specialization Roll against active Concealment or environmental difficulty.

A creature beyond **10 meters** can attempt this detection only if it has a special sense, Technique, preparation, or position that justifies reacting to that signal.

PERCEPTION RESULT	EFFECT
Failure	The attack keeps opening advantage
Success	Detects the action in time; the attacker gains no opening advantage against that creature

If the attack keeps opening advantage, it gains **+3** to the Attack Roll against targets that did not detect the action in time.

Attacking from Concealment always compromises Concealment, even if the attack misses.

After the attack, resolve approximate position or detection according to the scene.

MAINTAINING AND LOSING CONCEALMENT

Concealment holds while the creature does not give a sufficient signal to locate it.

Actions that compromise Concealment:

- making a melee attack
- making a ranged attack
- moving between cover
- running
- speaking loudly
- manipulating a visible or noisy object
- interacting with a light source
- changing position in a silent environment

Compromising Concealment does not automatically reveal exact position.

It means there is enough signal for nearby enemies to attempt location.

When a creature compromises Concealment, relevant creatures within **10 meters** can attempt a Perception Specialization Roll if they have an applicable sense.

Creatures beyond **10 meters** need a special sense, Technique, preparation, or circumstance that justifies detection.

Saying “I think it is there” or pointing to a suspected position does not reveal a concealed creature by itself.

Communicating suspicion enables area attacks or directed searching, but does not remove penalties or make the position exact.

UNCERTAIN APPROXIMATE POSITION

An action can reveal approximate position without revealing exact position.

Examples:

- an arrow leaves a patch of shrubs
- a stone falls from a ledge
- a voice comes from the west
- a shadow crosses behind smoke

Uncertain approximate position exists so the detector receives a playable clue without knowing whether they were right.

The player should know what their character perceived, but not whether that perception was correct.

PLAYER HIDDEN, CREATURE DETECTS

If the player is the one concealed:

1. The player rolls the same specialization used to hide, or the appropriate specialization if the fiction changed.
2. The Narrator rolls Perception for the creature trying to detect them.
3. If Perception beats Concealment, the creature locates the character’s real position.

4. If Perception does not beat Concealment, the Narrator rolls **1d8** and the creature acts toward the false position indicated by that direction, if its behavior justifies it.

The Narrator does not have to reveal whether the creature was right.

Only describe what the creature does.

CREATURE HIDDEN, PLAYER DETECTS

If a creature is the one concealed:

1. The player rolls Perception.
2. The Narrator secretly rolls the creature's Concealment.
3. The Narrator also secretly rolls **1d8** at the same time, declaring only that Concealment is being resolved.
4. If the player's Perception beats Concealment, the Narrator points to the real position.
5. If the player's Perception does not beat Concealment, the Narrator points to the false position indicated by the **1d8**.

The Narrator does not declare whether the player's roll succeeded or failed.

The point shown is what the character believes they perceived.

Ties favor the concealed creature.

FALSE DIRECTION

ID8	DIRECTION
1	Northwest
2	North
3	Northeast
4	West
5	East
6	Southwest
7	South
8	Southeast

On a grid, the **1d8** result points by default to the square adjacent to the concealed creature's real position in that direction.

If the creature occupies more than one square, use the adjacent square from the edge of its space in that direction.

If that square is invalid, blocked, or implausible, use the nearest plausible Cover, cell, or area in the same direction.

Without a grid, use a credible nearby zone in that direction.

DETECTING CONCEALED CREATURES

There is no universal separate action called Search.

Searching resolves as a Perception Specialization Roll, a Technique, or a scene-specific action if the Narrator requires one due to time, position, or pressure.

On success, the creature detects the position for itself.

It may communicate a suspicion or direction if the scene allows speech, pointing, or coordination, but that communication does not automatically reveal the creature to everyone.

PROVOKED DETECTION

Provoked detection occurs when a concealed creature produces a signal sufficient for others to have a chance to notice it.

The Narrator may:

- call for Perception
- use a fixed threshold
- reveal partial information if the signal is obvious

Provoked detection does not replace deliberate use of Perception or Techniques.

It resolves signals created by the concealed creature, not free scanning of the entire environment.

BALANCE LIMITS

Concealment needs limits because it can become too strong if it prevents too many responses.

Safety rules:

- hiding requires a physical, environmental, or technical basis
 - Concealment is measured by enemy or enemy group, not as a universal state
 - being hidden does not mean being untouchable
 - area effects still work if they cover the real position
 - attacking usually reveals or risks Concealment
 - specialized Perception can accelerate detection, but should not erase the whole signal game
 - creatures with non-visual senses can ignore or reduce visual Concealment
 - abilities, Techniques, or creatures can declare that they ignore Concealment under specific conditions
-

QUICK SUMMARY

ELEMENT	RULE
Cover	Physical protection that interferes with an attack line
Visibility	Clarity and distance at which details can be distinguished
Concealment	Lack of precise location by one or more enemies
Light Cover	-1 to the Attack Roll
Medium Cover	-3 to the Attack Roll
Total Cover	Does not allow direct attacks
Clear visual range	60 m
Hide in combat	Rhythm 5 , Attrition 1
Attacking from Concealment	Can grant +3 to the Attack Roll
Attacking from Concealment	Always compromises Concealment
Ties	Favor the concealed creature
Approximate position	Can be real or false depending on Perception and Concealment

ENVIRONMENTAL CONDITIONS

Environmental conditions give the Narrator a framework for assigning difficulty when the challenge comes from pressure external to the actor: terrain, weather, exposure, a dominant hostile presence, or the general threat level of a situation. They do not operate as a separate rule from the threshold system. They are the tool the Narrator uses to determine which difficulty tier applies when no other mechanic does.

If a specific rule already exists for an action, that rule takes precedence. If none exists, the severity of the environment establishes the threshold.

SOURCES OF PRESSURE

An environmental condition does not describe only weather or terrain. It describes any scene pressure that comes from outside the character and alters the normal way of acting.

The most common sources are three:

- **Ambient.** Terrain, weather, darkness, heat, cold, altitude, water, smoke, noise, or exposure.
- **Hostile.** A presence that dominates the situation even when no dedicated mechanic is yet resolving it: a clearly superior mortal creature, an anomalous entity, a primordial presence, a pursuit, or a space controlled by active threat.
- **Extranatural.** An alteration of the perceptible world caused by Limbo filtration or by Tauma acting on something that already exists.

The exact taxonomy of creatures belongs in the creature chapters. Here only one mechanical distinction matters: whether the pressure follows the natural logic of the world or comes from extranatural filtration.

TWO TYPES OF CONDITION

Natural conditions follow the physical laws of the world. They can be extreme — a hurricane, a volcanic field, a cave-in, the presence of an enormous predator, or an overwhelming mortal creature — but they operate within coherent physical logic.

Extranatural conditions are phenomena in the perceptible world that involve Limbo energy — the imperceptible parallel dimension, the origin of Tauma. Tauma does not generate phenomena from nothing: it transforms, modifies, amplifies what already exists in the material world. What distinguishes an extranatural condition from a natural one is not intensity or elements involved, but origin — any reaction that does not follow the natural logic of the world, produced by the imperceptible dimension filtering into the perceptible one.

A hostile presence can belong to either group. A mortal enemy or a material beast still creates natural pressure. An anomalous or primordial entity, or a presence made of pure Limbo energy, creates extranatural pressure even if it adopts visible or material form.

Observable markers are signs of this presence, not its definition. Physically contradictory states at the same point — fire and ice active at once, Light and Darkness simultaneously active with distinct physical effects — indicate direct and intense Limbo filtration. But not every extranatural condition produces visible contradictions; it may manifest as an amplification or transformation of something that already exists in the natural world.

The ground did not give or sink — it simply failed to push back with the expected resistance. Sound arrived after. With a slight, constant delay. Nothing in the landscape had changed. Only that gap between what was happening and what the body anticipated would happen.

SEVERITY LEVELS

Each severity level maps directly to one of the difficulty tiers in the threshold system. The Narrator assigns the environmental NR based on the specific intensity of the condition within that level — it is not a fixed value, but a reflection of how much that particular instance presses beyond the standard expression of its level.

SEVERITY	DIFFICULTY TIER	BASE	NR RANGE	TYPE
Mild	Fundamental	5	1	Natural
Moderate	Challenging	8	1–2	Natural
Severe	Rigorous	11	2–3	Natural or extranatural
Disastrous	Demanding	14	3–4	Natural or extranatural
Extreme	Extreme	17	4–5	Natural or extranatural

MILD (FUNDAMENTAL — 5 + NR)

Few disruptive factors. Manageable with basic attention.

Natural examples: light rain with gentle wind; irregular but familiar terrain; reduced visibility from light fog; uncomfortable but tolerable temperature; moderate ambient noise such as a nearby river or wind through trees.

MODERATE (CHALLENGING — 8 + NR)

Active factors demanding continuous adaptation. Affects concentration, coordination, or communication between characters.

Natural examples: moderate storm with reduced visibility; very irregular or marshy terrain; intense but not extreme heat or cold; noise that prevents verbal coordination; partial darkness from insufficient light sources or a covered moon.

Hostile examples: a nearby predator forcing constant caution; a clearly superior enemy whose mere presence prevents acting normally even before direct contact.

SEVERE (RIGOROUS — 11 + NR)

Significant environmental factors. Some tactical options are actively removed, not merely made harder.

Natural examples: strong storm with wind that prevents light projectiles and impedes movement; very rough terrain with real fall risk; sustained extreme temperature; near-total darkness with minimal visibility; combat in water or on an unstable surface.

Hostile examples: combat against a clearly superior mortal creature that forces cover, partial withdrawal, or restricted movement; a close pursuit by a predator that controls the ground.

Extranatural examples: terrain that yields or reacts in ways that don't correspond to the physics of the ground; darkness that physically responds to movement or sound; temperature that varies within a single space without gradient or visible source.

DISASTROUS (DEMANDING — 14 + NR)

Near-disabling conditions. May be natural phenomena at their most extreme, or extranatural influence of significant force.

Natural examples: active earthquake with collapses; maximum-intensity hurricane; active wildfire with unpredictable direction; maritime storm with waves overwhelming structures.

Hostile examples: a colossal or lethal creature whose presence turns the whole scene into immediate survival even before specific actions resolve; an entity that controls the space and forces action under constant suppression.

Extranatural examples: rain falling upward or at angles that contradict the wind; terrain that actively shifts shape without cause; darkness with a visible light source that produces no illumination; temperature varying several degrees in seconds without explanation.

EXTREME (EXTREME — 17 + NR)

The limit of what is survivable or executable. Extranatural conditions are common in this range. Three or more environmental forces in simultaneous active conflict, or phenomena the environment cannot sustain under natural logic.

Natural examples: maritime storm with simultaneous boarding and structure collapse; earthquake combined with a nearby volcanic eruption.

Hostile examples: a primordial presence or overwhelming predator that turns the entire scene into a survival condition; an encounter in which the enemy dominates the space so completely that several basic actions become nonviable.

Extranatural examples: multiple natural phenomena simultaneously amplified and transformed with no causal logic between them; Light and Darkness with simultaneous distinct physical effects; environment in active dimensional collapse; unstable physical rules — irregular gravity, perceptibly altered time.

NR ASSIGNMENT

The environmental NR reflects how much a specific instance of a condition presses beyond the standard expression of its severity level. An NR of 1 indicates the condition at its minimum expression for that level; a high NR indicates a condition at its peak, with multiple simultaneous factors, with a dominant hostile presence, or with a confirmed extranatural marker.

ENVIRONMENTAL NR	MEANING
1	Condition at its minimum expression for that severity level
2	Notable condition within its level; some compound factors
3	Intense condition; multiple simultaneous factors or extended duration
4	Condition at its peak, or first confirmed extranatural marker
5	Clear extranatural influence; reserved for Extreme severity

When a scene combines multiple sources of pressure — an intense physical condition, a dominant hostile presence, and/or an extranatural marker — the dominant source determines the severity tier. Secondary sources can add NR up to a maximum of +2. Do not stack NR from more than two sources.

NARRATOR TOOLS

The environmental NR expresses roll difficulty. It is the only fixed mechanical rule in this system. Beyond the threshold, the Narrator has two tools that can be applied when the situation narratively warrants it — neither has an automatic trigger.

Restrict. The Narrator can eliminate available actions when the condition justifies it. Not harder — unavailable. A hurricane does not add a negative modifier to sprinting; it makes sprinting impossible. The Narrator decides when a condition justifies removing an option, and which options.

Accelerate. The Narrator can add +1 to the Attrition cost of all non-free actions when the condition justifies active drain. This applies for as long as that environmental pressure lasts, and the Narrator determines when it ends.

Severity guides these decisions — an Extreme condition makes it likely the Narrator uses both tools; a Mild condition makes it unlikely either is used — but the decision is always narrative and contextual. Not every scenario at a given severity requires either tool.

RELEVANT SPECIALIZATIONS

The following specializations interact directly with environmental conditions. Their presence determines what options a character has to respond actively to scene pressure, rather than simply enduring it.

SPECIALIZATION	CONDITION TYPE	CONTEXT
Acclimatization (Tenacity)	Natural — environmental	Adapting to hostile or extreme environments
Tolerance (Tenacity)	Natural — physiological	Enduring pain and physical strain generated by conditions
Balance (Agility)	Natural — terrain	Reactive response to involuntary balance loss
Survival (Wisdom)	Natural — field	Practical decision-making in hostile environments

Specializations applicable to hostile or extranatural conditions — Perception, Intuition, Instinct, Resonance, Thaumaturgy — are described in their respective chapters. The general principle here is simple: scene pressure may require reading, enduring, or interpreting, not only physical resistance.

EXAMPLE

A group crosses a ruined bridge during a storm while a massive creature moves beneath the structure. The wind, wet surface, and unstable footing do not create a separate subsystem; they inform the threshold the Narrator assigns. If the storm is the main threat, the condition may be Moderate or Severe. If the dominant pressure becomes the creature’s presence, the level may rise even if the weather does not change. If the structure also bends in ways that do not follow material strain and sound arrives out of sync, the condition is extranatural.

SPECIALIZATIONS CATALOG

The specializations in this catalog describe concrete domains of practice. Each one defines what kind of actions it covers, what kind of problems it helps solve, and where its scope ends. They do not replace the Narrator's judgment, but they do establish a common basis for deciding when a roll is properly grounded.

The entries in this chapter do not exist to make the fiction rigid. They exist to give it shape. When two specializations seem close, the difference does not depend on the label alone, but on the kind of action each one represents.

When a specialization has a distinct baseline procedure, its entry states it directly. That includes the type of roll, what it is resolved against, which penalties appear most often, and whether failure allows an immediate new attempt.

When a test is not opposed by another creature and no other rule provides a specific defense, the starting point is not a difficulty invented from scratch for that isolated gesture. The base comes from the current environmental or scene condition. Distance, size, support, visibility, or stability adjust that value; they do not replace it.

Local modifiers should remain short and readable. In this catalog, -1 represents a minor hindrance, -2 a clear hindrance, and -3 a severe local hindrance. Since each difficulty tier rises in blocks of 3, a -3 modifier already amounts to pushing the test one full tier. If a situation would demand more than that, the scene condition should usually rise or the action should become restricted.

SHORT INDEX

- Strength
- Agility
- Tenacity
- Cunning
- Wisdom
- Intellect
- Composure

- Aura
- Presence

ATTRIBUTE SUMMARY

ATTRIBUTE	SPECIALIZATIONS
Strength	Jumping, Climbing, Throwing, Swimming, Gripping
Agility	Acrobatics, Dexterity, Balance, Riding
Tenacity	March, Acclimation, Tolerance
Cunning	Navigation, Tracking, Intuition, Deception, Improvisation, Theft
Wisdom	Perception, Survival, Medicine, Herbalism, Alchemy, Traps, Mining, Smithing, Tailoring, Jewelry, Engineering
Intellect	Identification, Interpretation, Linguistics, Thaumaturgy, History, Geography, Astronomy, Theology, Cryptology, Archaeology, Architecture, Belicology
Composure	Focus, Containment, Meditation, Poise
Aura	Instinct, Resonance, Bond, Taming
Presence	Leadership, Negotiation, Intimidation, Imitation, Stealth

STRENGTH

Strength specializations express power applied with intent. They do not reduce to simply “being strong”: they describe trained ways of projecting, sustaining, or imposing the body against weight, resistance, inertia, or direct contact.

Specializations in this block: Jumping , Climbing , Throwing , Swimming , Gripping

JUMPING

Jumping covers projecting the body through vertical or horizontal space through drive, weight transfer, and physical commitment. It is used when the main demand lies in generating movement with bodily power, not in fine maneuvering during the motion itself.

It is distinct from Acrobatics. If the main problem is rotating, landing with precision, or maintaining dynamic control in the air, then the relevant specialization stops being Jumping and becomes something else. Jumping resolves the launch, not fine movement control.

Mechanical Profile

- The baseline use of Jumping is an **active** action.
- It is resolved with a **Jumping S.R.** against a **threshold**, not an opposed roll.
- The base threshold depends on the kind of jump:

JUMP TYPE	BASE THRESHOLD
Horizontal	2 per meter
Vertical	2 per half meter

- It requires enough bodily support to generate the jump.
- It also requires enough physical space to execute the launch when the environment allows it.

Common Penalties

These modifiers are additive when they apply.

SITUATION	PENALTY
Heavy armor	- (piece grade + 1)
Medium armor	- (piece grade)
Slick ground	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level
Adverse environment	according to scene pressure or launch surface

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Terrain, weather, the takeoff surface, or the immediate situation adjust it or impose additional penalties at the Narrator's discretion.

Retries

Failing a jump does not grant an immediate automatic retry. The attempt can only be made again if the fiction produces a real new opportunity to launch and the previous failure has not closed that possibility.

Brief Example

A character tries to clear a gap between two rooftops before the edge gives way beneath their feet. The roll determines whether they can generate enough force to reach the other side.

CLIMBING

Climbing covers ascending or descending surfaces through body placement based on strength, traction, and support of one's own weight. It is used when the character must gain or lose height by relying on grips, cracks, ledges, or unstable points of support.

Climbing does not replace Gripping. Gripping decides whether contact holds when something tries to pull you loose or when you need to retain a hold under pressure. Climbing describes the body's advance across a surface; Gripping describes the firmness of contact.

Mechanical Profile

- The baseline use of Climbing is an **active** action.
- It is resolved with a **Climbing S.R.** against a **threshold**, not an opposed roll.
- The base threshold comes from the current environmental or scene condition.

The quality of the handholds, the incline, the stability of the surface, and the height of the segment adjust that base value.

- It requires a surface or structure with usable points of support.
- It also requires enough physical contact to begin or sustain the ascent, descent, or suspension.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Heavy armor	- (piece grade + 1)
Medium armor	- (piece grade)
Wet surface	-1
Brittle or crumbling surface	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Climbing can only be attempted again if the character still has enough support and the previous failure did not cause a fall, loss of purchase, or closure of the route.

Brief Example

A character climbs the outer wall of a rain-soaked tower while the stone loses purchase beneath the weather. The roll measures whether they can keep ascending without losing pace or support.

THROWING

Throwing covers projecting objects through trained force, angle, and bodily transfer. It is used when the character must give an object reach or power and the main demand lies in the physical impulse that drives the throw.

It does not by itself replace thrown weapons or every form of fine precision. When the central problem is striking with a specialized combat tool, the resolution may involve other layers of the system. Throwing describes the ability to project something with trained physical force.

Mechanical Profile

- The baseline use of Throwing is an **active** action.
- If the target is a creature in combat, it is resolved as a **Throwing S.R.** against **Defense**.
- If the target is a point, mechanism, opening, or place in the environment, it is resolved against a **threshold**.

Without active defense, the scene condition sets the base threshold. Distance, target size, and impact-point stability adjust it.

- It requires a throwable object or a suitable thrown weapon.
- It also requires enough throwing line to complete the trajectory.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Improvised but throwable object	-1
Poorly balanced object	-2
Partially obstructed trajectory	-2
Strong crosswind	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Throwing can be repeated if the character has another real attempt available and the fiction still preserves line, time, and resource to do it.

Brief Example

A character throws a hooked rope toward a distant ledge before the current carries them downstream. The roll defines whether the throw gains the distance and angle it needs.

SWIMMING

Swimming covers moving the body through water through propulsion, breathing, and sustained physical control. It is used when the character must travel, stay afloat, or advance against a body of water that offers real resistance.

It is distinct from March or Acclimation. March governs prolonged locomotion in general; Acclimation governs adaptation to hostile environments. Swimming describes the concrete competency of moving through water without letting it break the body or steal momentum.

Mechanical Profile

- The baseline use of Swimming is an **active** action.
- It is resolved with a **Swimming S.R.** against a **threshold**.
- The base threshold comes from the current environmental or scene condition.

Current, visibility, temperature, actual distance, the character's load, and the hostility of the aquatic environment adjust that base value.

- It requires real contact with a body of water that demands bodily propulsion.
- It also requires enough mobility to execute stroke, kick, or flotation control.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Heavy armor	- (piece grade + 2)
Medium armor	- (piece grade + 1)
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Current, hostile water, and general environmental pressure should first enter through the scene condition. They should not be charged again as a local penalty unless there is an additional factor the base threshold did not already capture.

Retries

As long as the character remains afloat or still has real room to maneuver, they may attempt further rolls. Every additional attempt remains subject to environmental pressure and its consequences.

Brief Example

A character crosses a rough channel while carrying gear as the current tries to drag them off line. The roll decides whether they maintain enough progress to reach the far bank.

GRIPPING

Gripping covers holding, retaining, and applying force through direct contact with trained control. It is used when the action depends on not losing purchase: pinning an arm, holding a taut rope, keeping a weapon locked in place, or stopping something from slipping free.

It is distinct from Climbing. A full ascent may call for Climbing, but the moment when the hand must not let go, or when a target tries to break free of control, belongs to Gripping. The difference lies in whether the main action is progressing across a surface or dominating the point of contact.

Mechanical Profile

- Gripping may be an **active** or **reactive** action in combat.
- If another creature actively resists, it is resolved as an **opposed test**.
- If the action consists of holding, stabilizing, or retaining something without direct living opposition, it is resolved against a **threshold**.

When there is no active resistance, the environmental or scene condition establishes the base threshold. Weight, instability, contact surface, and the pressure trying to break the hold adjust it.

- It requires direct physical contact with the target, object, or support point.
- It also requires a bodily position that allows retention force to be applied.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Slippery surface or target covered in fluid	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level
Compromised grip or unstable position	-2

Retries

Failure does not grant an automatic new attempt in the same instant. It can only be tried again if the character still has reach, contact, or a real new window to establish the hold.

Brief Example

A character holds another by the wrist at the edge of a collapse while the pull of falling weight starts to overpower them. The roll determines whether the grip holds before both go down.

AGILITY

Agility specializations express fine bodily control. They do not revolve around power, but around clean execution: maneuvering, maintaining posture, acting with precision, or controlling the body when error carries an immediate cost.

Specializations in this block: `Acrobatics`, `Dexterity`, `Balance`, `Riding`

ACROBATICS

Acrobatics covers complex bodily maneuvers: rolling, redirecting momentum, absorbing falls, and crossing difficult spaces without losing continuity of movement. It is used when the main problem is not explosive launch or simply staying upright, but coordinating the whole body through a dynamic sequence.

It is distinct from Jumping or Balance. Jumping resolves explosive launch. Balance resolves sustained stability. Acrobatics begins when the body must chain complex movement and remain functional inside it.

Mechanical Profile

- Acrobatics may be an **active** or **reactive** action.
- If it directly answers an active physical pressure, it may be resolved as an **opposed test**.
- If the challenge comes from the route, the obstacles, or the environment, it is resolved against a **threshold**.

Without active opposition, the scene condition sets the base threshold. The complexity of the maneuver, the narrowness of the space, and the continuity of movement adjust it.

- It requires enough bodily space to execute the maneuver.
- It also requires enough functional mobility to roll, redirect, or absorb movement.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Heavy armor	- (piece grade + 2)
Medium armor	- (piece grade + 1)
Narrow space or interrupted maneuver	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It can only be attempted again if the character still has space, momentum, or a real new window to execute the maneuver.

Brief Example

A character rolls out of a fall from a ledge, passes through a gap in the rubble, and regains position before enemy pressure closes the opening. The roll decides whether they keep continuity without losing control.

DEXTERITY

Dexterity covers fine manipulations of hands and body: operating a delicate mechanism, placing a tool at an exact point, or executing a technical gesture with no real margin for error. It is used when the main demand lies in manual precision, not in broad bodily movement.

It is distinct from Theft. Theft resolves taking something without detection. Dexterity resolves the technical quality of the manipulation.

Mechanical Profile

- The baseline use of Dexterity is an **active** action.
- In most cases it is resolved against a **threshold**.
- It only becomes an **opposed test** if another creature is actively answering the same manipulation in the same instant.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. The size of the piece, the delicacy of the operation, the quality of the tools, and time pressure adjust it.

- It requires enough manual access to the object, mechanism, or work area.
- It also requires a minimum functional window of time to complete the manipulation.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Improvised tools	-1
Partial darkness or reduced visibility	-2
Awkward position or restricted access	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be attempted again if failure does not break the mechanism, consume the critical resource, or close the fiction's real opportunity to manipulate it.

Brief Example

A character tries to disable an exposed mechanism from an unstable position before a counterweight locks again. The roll defines whether the manipulation is completed without triggering the system.

BALANCE

Balance covers the ability to sustain posture and function when an external force or unstable surface tries to break the body's base. It is used when the main problem is not losing footing, not falling, and not yielding position.

It is distinct from Acrobatics. Acrobatics resolves dynamic movement sequences; Balance resolves reactive stability and sustained posture.

Mechanical Profile

- Balance is primarily a **reactive** action.
- If another creature directly tries to unbalance the character, it may be resolved as an **opposed test**.
- If the threat comes from the surface or from an impersonal force, it is resolved against a **threshold**.

Without active opposition, the scene condition sets the base threshold. The narrowness of the support, the violence of the shake, and the instability of the surface adjust it.

- It requires a support base or contact point from which posture can be sustained.
- It also requires enough bodily reaction to correct the loss of stability.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Wet or moving surface	-1
Narrow or deformed footing	-2
Heavy armor	- (piece grade + 1)
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It is only repeated when a new loss of stability occurs. A single unbalancing event does not grant unlimited additional attempts.

Brief Example

A character holds position on the deck of a storm-tossed ship while a lateral jolt tries to break their combat footing. The roll determines whether they keep their base.

RIDING

Riding covers the technical control of a moving mount: staying in the saddle, directing under pressure, and acting tactically without breaking the coordination between rider and mount. It is used when the main problem is operating from the mount as a functional system.

It is distinct from Taming. Taming concerns bond and instinctive handling; Riding concerns technical control in motion.

Mechanical Profile

- The baseline use of Riding is an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It only becomes an **opposed test** if another creature directly tries to destabilize the mount or rider.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Speed, the sharpness of the turn, terrain, and the pressure received by the mount adjust it.

- It requires an available, functional mount.
- It also requires basic control of the saddle, reins, or equivalent point of support.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Agitated or wounded mount	-2
Irregular or slick terrain	-2
Tight maneuver at high speed	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be repeated while the mount retains functional control and the maneuver has not already become a fall, a bolt, or a loss of position.

Brief Example

A character turns sharply to cut off a fleeing enemy while keeping their weapon ready and preventing the mount from losing line on unstable ground. The roll decides whether they complete the maneuver without breaking control.

TENACITY

Tenacity specializations express bodily continuity under pressure. They do not describe power, but the ability to stay functional when exertion, attrition, environment, or pain have already started to take their price.

Specializations in this block: March, Acclimation, Tolerance

MARCH

March covers sustained locomotion: keeping pace, covering distance, and arriving in functional condition when time, terrain, or travel demand are already extracting a cost. It is used when the central problem is continuing to move through a long segment without breaking pace.

It is distinct from Acclimation. March covers sustained locomotion; Acclimation enters when a hostile environment degrades the journey from outside. It also stays separate from Tolerance, which enters when the journey has already produced pain, affliction, or active bodily degradation.

Mechanical Profile

- In combat, March appears as a secondary **reactive** action when the scene demands sustained movement.
- In exploration, it functions mostly **automatically**.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It only becomes an **opposed test** if another creature directly forces the collapse of the movement or cuts off advance as sustained pressure.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Segment length, terrain irregularity, gear load, and demanded pace adjust it.

- It requires real sustained movement, not just a brief maneuver.
- It also requires that the character retain functional capacity to keep advancing through the segment.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Sustained heavy load	-2
Broken, soft, or unstable terrain	-2
Forced pace without enough pause	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

March is evaluated again for new segments, pace changes, or prolongation of the effort. Failure does not reset the journey: it carries functional degradation forward while the travel continues.

Brief Example

A character keeps the pace of a retreating column across broken ground before dawn. The roll defines whether they arrive still functional or whether the journey starts costing more than they can sustain.

ACCLIMATION

Acclimation covers physiological adaptation to hostile environmental conditions: extreme cold, heat, altitude, severe humidity, or aggressive atmospheres. It is used when the central problem is that the environment begins to degrade the character even if they are still moving, thinking, or acting correctly.

It is distinct from Survival. Survival decides what to do in hostile terrain; Acclimation decides how much the environment punishes the body. It also stays separate from Tolerance, which enters when the suffering is already inside the body as pain, affliction, or active deterioration.

Mechanical Profile

- In combat, Acclimation usually enters as a **reactive** action when hostile conditions intrude into the scene.
- In exploration, it functions mostly **automatically**.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**, not as an opposed roll.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Temperature, altitude, humidity, aggressive atmosphere, and exposure duration adjust that value.

- It requires real exposure to a hostile or extreme environmental condition.
- It also requires enough time or contact for the environment to start degrading the character.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Sudden exposure without prior adaptation	-2
Clothing, shelter, or environmental protection compromised	-2
Abrupt transition between opposing conditions	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Acclimation may be evaluated again while exposure continues or changes in intensity. A failure does not erase the process: it leaves active consequences while the environment keeps pressing.

Brief Example

A character crosses an icy ridge after leaving a temperate zone with no real time to adapt. The roll decides whether the body falls into rhythm with the cold and altitude or starts to degrade.

TOLERANCE

Tolerance covers remaining functional under pain, affliction, or already active physiological punishment. It is used when the body is already wounded, intoxicated, degraded, or pressured and the question is not whether the character avoids the damage, but whether they can continue operating in spite of it.

It is distinct from Acclimation. Acclimation resists what the environment does to the body. Tolerance resists what the body is already suffering. It also stays separate from Containment, which enters when the threat of collapse is mental or emotional.

If the main question is whether the body keeps functioning despite pain, affliction, or already active physiological degradation, Tolerance is the right specialization.

Mechanical Profile

- Tolerance functions mostly as a **reactive** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may interact with an already defined opposition when a creature, toxin, or hostile effect maintains active physiological pressure.

When there is no other defined opposition, the environmental or scene condition establishes the base threshold. The number of afflictions, the intensity of pain, and the duration of bodily punishment adjust that value.

- It requires bodily suffering, affliction, or active physiological degradation.
- It also requires that the character still be trying to act or remain functional under that pressure.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Open wound, bleeding, or acute pain	-2
Each additional active physical affliction beyond the first	-1
Lack of treatment or immediate relief	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Tolerance is evaluated again when a new wave of pain appears, a new affliction takes hold, or a critical action must be completed under bodily punishment. The previous failure continues to matter while the body remains degraded.

Brief Example

A character tries to complete a decisive action while carrying an open wound and venom has already begun to degrade the body. The roll determines whether they remain functional long enough to finish it.

CUNNING

Cunning specializations express adaptive reading, opportunism, and situational intelligence. They do not depend on formal knowledge or brute force, but on reading the moment, detecting indirect structure, and exploiting openings when the problem does not come with a clean procedure.

Specializations in this block: Navigation, Tracking, Intuition, Deception, Improvisation, Theft

NAVIGATION

Navigation covers knowing where one is, where one is heading, and which route makes the most sense when the environment offers no obvious answer. It is used when the central question is not following someone else, but not getting lost and building one's own functional direction.

It is distinct from Tracking. Tracking follows another's traces; Navigation resolves one's own position and direction. It also stays separate from Geography, which supplies formal regional knowledge rather than immediate field reading.

Mechanical Profile

- Navigation functions mostly as an **active** exploration action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**, not as an opposed roll.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Visibility, repetition of terrain, lack of landmarks, and urgency of movement adjust that value.

- It requires an environment whose position, direction, or route is not self-evident.
- It also requires landmarks, terrain reading, or enough margin to construct functional orientation.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Fog, darkness, or broken visibility	-2
Labyrinthine, uniform, or landmarkless environment	-2
Time pressure or pursuit	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Navigation may be reevaluated when available information, terrain, or the point of reference changes. Failure may leave residual disorientation and is not cleanly redone without new field reading.

Brief Example

A character tries to get the group out of a forest where every path is beginning to look the same. The roll decides whether they can reconstruct a reliable direction before more time is lost.

TRACKING

Tracking covers following someone or something through the marks they left in the environment. It is used when the central question is not finding one's own route, but reconstructing another's movement history.

It is distinct from Navigation. Navigation resolves one's own advance; Tracking reads someone else's passage. It also stays separate from Perception, though it may rely on it when traces are subtle.

Mechanical Profile

- Tracking functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**, not as an opposed roll.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Freshness of the tracks, ground type, weather, and any concealment attempt adjust that value.

- It requires a history of passage actually inscribed in the environment.
- It also requires enough time or continuity to read signs instead of moving blindly.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Hard, dry, or mark-poor ground	-1
Rain, traffic, or disturbance degrading the trail	-2
Deliberate erasure or fragmented trail	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Tracking may be reevaluated when new tracks appear, terrain changes, or the trail reemerges. Failure may mean temporary or permanent loss of the current trail.

Brief Example

A character tries to follow a wounded creature before the rain erases the marks completely. The roll determines whether the trail holds or is lost.

INTUITION

Intuition covers inferring danger, hidden motives, or unseen structure before they manifest clearly. It is used when the central question is not what the character sees, but what they conclude from tension, dissonance, or incomplete signals.

It is distinct from Perception. Perception notices what is present; Intuition infers what is not visible. It also stays separate from Instinct, because Instinct arises from essence, while Intuition is trained adaptive intelligence.

Mechanical Profile

- Intuition functions mostly as a **reactive** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may edge into an **opposed test** when another creature is actively concealing intent or danger.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Ambiguity, situation complexity, and another party's ability to hide intent adjust that value.

- It requires a situation with hidden meaning, latent risk, or motive not directly visible.
- It also requires enough partial information for the inference to have a basis, even if not explicit.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Contradictory signs or too many variables at once	-1
Deliberate deception or careful concealment	-2
Urgent pressure cutting off reading time	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Intuition is reevaluated when new clues appear or the situation changes. Repeating it without new information rarely produces a better reading of the same moment.

Brief Example

A character feels that the friendly conversation in front of them is too carefully arranged to be innocent. The roll decides whether they read the danger before the trap closes.

DECEPTION

Deception covers making another person believe something false through lies, omission, or deliberate framing. It is used when the central question is not whether the character seems like someone else, but whether they can impose a credible false narrative.

It is distinct from Imitation. Imitation reproduces another person; Deception fabricates a false version of the situation. It also stays separate from Intimidation, because this is not about yielding through fear but about manipulated belief.

Mechanical Profile

- Deception functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved as an **opposed test** against the target's reading or suspicion.
- It may fall back to a **threshold** if there is no active opposition but the lie still faces real situational difficulty.

Without defined active opposition, the scene condition sets the base threshold. Plausibility, pressure of the moment, and the target's predisposition adjust that value.

- It requires a target capable of processing the false information or manipulative framing.
- It also requires a narrative, omission, or lie that can minimally hold together in the scene.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Complex or hard-to-sustain lie	-1
Target already distrustful or alert	-2
Visible contradiction with present facts	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Deception may be reevaluated if the frame, story, or target changes. Failure before the same person usually leaves suspicion that makes insisting on the same lie harder.

Brief Example

A character tries to convince a guard that they are authorized to pass before someone with real information arrives to expose the lie. The roll decides whether the story holds.

IMPROVISATION

Improvisation covers solving an immediate problem with imperfect means, without prior procedure, and under pressure. It is used when the central question is not whether the character masters a formal technique, but whether they can invent a functional way out with what they have on hand.

It is distinct from Engineering or Dexterity. Improvisation creates a solution under restriction; the others may support its execution when structural logic or fine precision are required.

Mechanical Profile

- Improvisation functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**, not as an opposed roll.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Urgency, poverty of resources, fragility of the solution, and complexity of the problem adjust that value.

- It requires a problem with no prepared procedure or no ideal tool available.
- It also requires minimal materials, environment, or resources that can be converted into a functional solution.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Clearly inadequate or scarce resources	-2
Minimal time or immediate pressure	-2
Solution that also requires fine technical precision	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Improvisation may be reevaluated if resources change, a new idea appears, or the situation opens another way out. Failure may consume materials or close the window that allowed improvisation.

Brief Example

A character tries to seal a leak with gear not meant for that job before the whole space is ruined. The roll defines whether the solution holds.

THEFT

Theft covers taking an object or resource from someone else without direct confrontation, through opportunity, distraction, and enough execution that the removal is not noticed in time. It is used when the central question is not whether the character moves unseen in general, but whether they can lift something from another's hands or from a controlled space.

It is distinct from Dexterity. Dexterity gives fine manual precision; Theft defines opportunistic taking. It also stays separate from Stealth, though it may rely on it when not being registered is also required.

Mechanical Profile

- Theft functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved as an **opposed test** against the holder's attention or safeguarding.
- It may be resolved against a **threshold** when the opportunity depends more on the environment than on active vigilance.

When there is no defined active opposition, the environmental or scene condition establishes the base threshold. Proximity, object exposure, flow of attention, and ease of escape adjust that value.

- It requires an object or resource accessible without direct confrontation.
- It also requires a real opportunity for removal through distraction, closeness, or carelessness.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Well-secured, stored, or watched object	-2
Little room to hide the gesture or withdraw	-1
Need for particularly fine manual precision	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Theft may be reevaluated if environmental attention changes or a new opportunity emerges. Failure before the same target usually raises alert and makes repeating the attempt much harder.

Brief Example

A character tries to slip a key off a distracted guard before the exchange ends. The roll determines whether the removal is clean or whether alert rises immediately.

WISDOM

Wisdom specializations express attentive reading of reality, practical judgment, and applied work on bodies, environments, and materials. They are not oriented toward opportunistic inference or pure academic knowledge, but toward seeing well, deciding well, and operating with sound judgment in the concrete world.

Specializations in this block: Perception, Survival, Medicine, Herbalism, Alchemy, Traps, Mining, Smithing, Tailoring, Jewelry, Engineering

ARTS AND CRAFTS

Inside **Wisdom**, **Arts and Crafts** does not appear here as a single specialization, but as an umbrella for practical and artistic disciplines. It does not cover material work alone: it also includes performative disciplines when their center is practice, execution, and preparation of a work.

This includes expressions such as:

- Music
- Dance
- Juggling
- Puppetry
- Stage Acting

These disciplines belong here because they are not resolved through social presence alone. They require rehearsal, method, technical control, and applied judgment over a concrete form of production.

ARTISTIC AND CRAFT ACTIVITY

During any day, a character may dedicate **4 hours** to producing an artistic or crafted piece. To do so, they choose a difficulty that represents the work's complexity and attempt an **S.R.** with the corresponding discipline or specialization within **Arts and Crafts**.

If they succeed, they gain the associated payout. This represents successful sale, commission, exhibition, or circulation of the work.

DIFFICULTY	GAIN
Foundational	2d4 Obsidian Shekels
Challenging	2d6 Obsidian Shekels
Rigorous	2d8 Obsidian Shekels
Demanding	2d10 Obsidian Shekels
Extreme	2d12 Jade Shekels

- The specialization used must match the work produced.
- The character needs minimum tools and materials to produce the piece.
- Each 4-hour block allows only one artistic or craft attempt.
- If the test fails, the character gains nothing from that block.

PERCEPTION

Perception covers actively noticing significant details in the environment: visual, auditory, or physical signals that are present but could be missed. It is used when the central question is not what something means, but whether the character detects it at all.

It is distinct from Intuition. Intuition infers; Perception detects. It also stays separate from Tracking, though it may support it when traces are subtle.

Mechanical Profile

- Perception may function as an **active** or **reactive** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may interact with opposition if another creature is actively hiding something in that same instant.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Illumination, distance, noise, cover, and subtlety of the detail adjust that value.

- It requires that the detail actually exist in the scene.
- It also requires enough sensory line or exposure for it to be detected.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Poor light, fog, or partial cover	-2
Noise, interference, or sensory overload	-1
Tiny, distant, or brief detail	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Perception may be reevaluated if the angle, exposure, or moment changes. Repeating it without new information rarely improves the same static reading.

Brief Example

A character tries to detect whether someone armed is hiding in a crowd before the situation escalates. The roll decides whether they fix the detail in time.

SURVIVAL

Survival covers field judgment for staying alive and functional in hostile environments: water, shelter, resources, immediate risks, and practical decisions under natural pressure. It is used when the central question is not resisting the environment in the body, but deciding how to operate within it.

It is distinct from Acclimation. Acclimation resists the environment; Survival decides how to inhabit it. It also stays separate from Medicine, which treats damage already received.

Mechanical Profile

- Survival functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**, not as an opposed roll.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Scarcity, hostility, uncertainty, time pressure, and available resources adjust that value.

- It requires a hostile or uncertain environment where real practical decisions must be made.
- It also requires enough room for those decisions to be applied.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Unfamiliar or especially hostile environment	-2
Scarce or damaged resources	-1
Time pressure or immediate threat	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Survival may be reevaluated when the environment changes, new resources appear, or the group tries a different response. Failure may consume time or worsen position.

Brief Example

A character must decide where to shelter the group before a hostile storm makes open ground unlivable. The roll defines whether their judgment is enough.

MEDICINE

Medicine covers treating, stabilizing, and restoring bodily function through trained healing practice. It is used when the central question is how to intervene on damage, not merely how to endure it.

It is distinct from Tolerance. Tolerance resists damage; Medicine intervenes on it. It also stays separate from Herbalism or Alchemy, which provide resources or compounds.

Mechanical Profile

- Medicine functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may be under scene pressure if applied in combat or under threat.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Severity of the damage, time available, tools, and stability of the patient adjust that value.

- It requires an injured, sick, or physically compromised target.
- It also requires enough bodily access and practical room to intervene.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Poor tools or improvised field conditions	-1
Severe bleeding, instability, or trauma	-2
Active pressure, movement, or nearby danger	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Medicine may be reevaluated if the patient's state changes, better resources arrive, or another treatment window opens. Failure may close part of that margin.

Brief Example

A character tries to stabilize an ally before blood loss removes them from the scene entirely. The roll decides whether they can keep them in play.

HERBALISM

Herbalism covers identifying, gathering, and applying useful flora for practical, medicinal, or material purposes. It is used when the central question is how to read a plant's value and exploit it correctly.

It is distinct from Medicine. Medicine treats; Herbalism provides and recognizes plant resource. It also stays separate from Alchemy, which transforms ingredients into refined compounds.

Mechanical Profile

- Herbalism functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Rarity of the species, seasonality, visibility, state of preservation, and risk of confusion adjust that value.

- It requires access to relevant flora or to a usable sample.
- It also requires minimum time to recognize, gather, or prepare its basic use.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Rare, degraded, or out-of-season flora	-1
Dense, toxic, or hard-to-read environment	-2
High risk of confusing similar species	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Herbalism may be reevaluated if the environment changes, another sample appears, or better access to the species is obtained. Failure may spoil the material or cause false identification.

Brief Example

A character looks for a plant useful for easing a mild infection before the condition worsens. The roll decides whether they recognize and gather the right one.

ALCHEMY

Alchemy covers transforming ingredients into functional compounds: antidotes, reagents, toxins, or extracts. It is used when the central question is not recognizing raw material, but producing an effect through learned preparation.

It is distinct from Herbalism. Herbalism obtains and identifies ingredients; Alchemy transforms them. It also stays separate from Medicine, which applies clinical treatment.

Mechanical Profile

- Alchemy functions mostly as an **active** action outside immediate pressure.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Complexity of the mixture, purity of ingredients, precision required, and stability of the environment adjust that value.

- It requires appropriate ingredients.
- It also requires minimal equipment or conditions for mixing, distilling, or preparing the compound.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Incomplete, impure, or degraded ingredients	-2
Improvised or unstable equipment	-1
Delicate, reactive, or demanding compound	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Alchemy may be reevaluated if ingredients, method, or conditions change. Failure may consume material or spoil the batch.

Brief Example

A character tries to prepare an antidote before the poison gains too much ground. The roll decides whether the compound comes out usable.

TRAPS

Traps covers building, identifying, preparing, or disarming condition-triggered systems. It is used when the central question is how a delayed mechanism responds to the environment or to another person's passage.

It is distinct from Dexterity. Dexterity gives fine manual precision; Traps defines the logic of the system. It also stays separate from Engineering, which covers broader structures and mechanisms.

Mechanical Profile

- Traps functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may involve indirect opposition if another person designed or concealed the trap with real intent.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Trigger complexity, concealment, fragility of the system, and pressure of the moment adjust that value.

- It requires enough access to the trap or to the space where it will be prepared.
- It also requires materials, tools, or minimal conditions to intervene on it.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Complex or poorly visible mechanism	-2
Time pressure or immediate risk of activation	-2
Poor tools or restricted access	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Traps may be reevaluated if access changes, the system is better understood, or the approach is replaced. Failure may trigger the trap or degrade the chance to intervene safely.

Brief Example

A character tries to identify and disarm a mechanism before someone in the group steps into it blindly. The roll decides whether the logic of the trap yields in time.

MINING

Mining covers reading the subsoil, identifying useful veins, and extracting material without destroying what surrounds it. It is used when the central question is how to exploit the earth or assess its practical stability.

It is distinct from Engineering or Smithing. Mining extracts and reads material; the others transform it or structure it.

Mechanical Profile

- Mining functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Hardness of the ground, stability of the cavity, quality of tools, and collapse risk adjust that value.

- It requires access to relevant vein, rock, or underground environment.
- It also requires tools or at least a minimum method of extraction or evaluation.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Unstable rock, poor vein, or compromised cavity	-2
Insufficient tools	-1
High risk of collapse or contamination of the material	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Mining may be reevaluated if the work point changes or better access is obtained. Failure may collapse part of the environment or ruin the immediate extraction.

Brief Example

A character tries to extract a useful sample without bringing the tunnel down on the group. The roll defines whether they read the rock correctly.

SMITHING

Smithing covers forging, repairing, and evaluating structural or functional metalwork. It is used when the central question is whether a metal object can be produced or restored through real working judgment.

It is distinct from Jewelry. Jewelry works in fine detail and small value; Smithing works in function, form, and structural resistance.

Mechanical Profile

- Smithing functions mostly as an **active** action in workshop or narrative scenes.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Quality of metal, access to heat, tools, time, and functional precision adjust that value.

- It requires workable metal and minimum forging or repair conditions.
- It also requires enough time for real intervention.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Damaged, impure, or hard-to-work metal	-1
Incomplete forge or tools	-2
Critical repair with minimal error margin	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Smithing may be reevaluated if the material, tool, or working margin changes. Failure may warp the piece or make it unsafe.

Brief Example

A character tries to restore functionality to a critical piece of equipment before it is needed again. The roll decides whether the repair holds.

TAILORING

Tailoring covers making, adjusting, and repairing garments or flexible pieces with practical function. It is used when the central question is maintaining functional textile or flexible-material work.

It is distinct from Jewelry or Smithing. Its domain is cloth, leather, fiber, and functional garment construction.

Mechanical Profile

- Tailoring functions mostly as an **active** action in narrative scenes.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. State of the material, access to tools, precision of fit, and urgency adjust that value.

- It requires workable flexible material.
- It also requires minimum access to sewing, cutting, or repair.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Poor material, torn material, or difficult match	-1
Incomplete tools or improvised field conditions	-1
Delicate fit or critically functional garment	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Tailoring may be reevaluated if the material or method changes. Failure may waste cloth, deform the fit, or leave the garment unusable.

Brief Example

A character tries to repair a flexible piece of equipment before the group has to rely on it again. The roll decides whether it becomes functional.

JEWELRY

Jewelry covers fine work on small objects, stones, settings, and valuable pieces. It is used when the central question is intervening on something delicate where error destroys value or fine function.

It is distinct from Smithing. Smithing resolves structural-scale functional metal; Jewelry resolves fine precision and small artisanal value.

Mechanical Profile

- Jewelry functions mostly as an **active** action in workshop or narrative scenes.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Size of the piece, fragility, value of the material, and precision required adjust that value.

- It requires a small or valuable piece susceptible to fine work.
- It also requires tools and manual control sufficient to intervene on it.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Tiny, fragile, or high-value piece	-2
Poor precision tools	-2
Unknown material or very delicate setting	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Jewelry may be reevaluated if access, tools, or available piece change. Failure may damage the object's value or integrity.

Brief Example

A character tries to work on a small, valuable piece without ruining it. The roll determines whether the fine work comes out clean.

ENGINEERING

Engineering covers understanding and producing structural or mechanical logic in devices, mechanisms, and complex constructions. It is used when the central question is not the isolated material, but how a structure or system functions as a whole.

It is distinct from Traps. Traps works with delayed activation systems; Engineering works with structure and mechanism in a broader sense. It also stays separate from material crafts, which may provide the pieces.

Mechanical Profile

- Engineering functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. System complexity, access to its parts, quality of tools, and pressure of the moment adjust that value.

- It requires a structure, mechanism, or device that can be read or intervened on as a system.
- It also requires enough access for inspection, adjustment, or design.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Complex, strange, or partially hidden system	-2
Poor tools or restricted access	-1
High risk of cascading failure or structural damage	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Engineering may be reevaluated if better access, new information, or a different approach appears. Failure may compromise the system or close the margin for safe intervention.

Brief Example

A character tries to understand how to open or divert a complex mechanism before time runs out. The roll decides whether they grasp the system's logic fast enough.

INTELLECT

Intellect specializations express formal knowledge, organized analysis, and understanding of learned systems. They do not rely on situational instinct or immediate practical judgment, but on structured memory, study, and the ability to apply knowledge frameworks to the right problem.

Specializations in this block: Identification, Interpretation, Linguistics, Thaumaturgy, History, Geography, Astronomy, Theology, Cryptology, Archaeology, Architecture, Belicology

IDENTIFICATION

Identification covers recognizing what something is through informed analysis and organized knowledge. It is used when the central question is not what something means, but what kind of object, creature, or phenomenon stands before the character.

It is distinct from Interpretation. Identification says what something is; Interpretation extracts what it implies. It also stays separate from Perception, which detects before classifying.

Mechanical Profile

- Identification functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Rarity, state of preservation, distortion of the sample, and specificity of the domain adjust that value.

- It requires an object, creature, or phenomenon that can be classified or recognized.
- It also requires enough observable information to compare it against prior knowledge.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Incomplete, damaged, or altered sample	-1
Rare or highly specific species, phenomenon, or object	-2
Hasty examination or limited access	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated if a better sample appears, new information emerges, or more time for examination becomes available. Repeating it over the same unchanged evidence rarely improves the result.

Brief Example

A character tries to determine whether a found artifact is a thaumatic relic, an unusual mechanism, or an elaborate forgery. The roll decides whether they classify it correctly.

INTERPRETATION

Interpretation covers extracting meaning from signals, patterns, and structures through organized analysis. It is used when the central question is no longer detection or recognition, but understanding what the material in front of the character implies.

It is distinct from Perception. Perception notices what is there; Interpretation decides what it means. It also stays separate from Intuition, which resolves rapid inference without the same level of structured analysis.

Mechanical Profile

- Interpretation functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Ambiguity of the pattern, number of variables, and depth of context adjust that value.

- It requires information, a pattern, or a structure already detected.
- It also requires enough basis to extract meaning instead of speculating in a vacuum.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Fragmentary or contradictory information	-1
Complex or deliberately ambiguous pattern	-2
Time pressure that cuts off analysis	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated if new data arrives or the interpretive frame changes. Without new information, repeating it rarely adds real understanding.

Brief Example

A character tries to reconstruct what happened in a sealed room from remains, trajectories, and marks of damage. The roll decides whether they grasp the scene's meaning.

LINGUISTICS

Linguistics covers understanding, analyzing, and decoding systems of language and formal communication. It is used when the central question is whether a text or speech can be understood as a real language or writing system.

It is distinct from Cryptology. Linguistics works with real language even when unknown; Cryptology enters when the system was designed to hide information. It also stays separate from Negotiation or Leadership, which belong to the social use of speech.

Mechanical Profile

- Linguistics functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Rarity of the language, linguistic distance, state of the text, and grammatical complexity adjust that value.

- It requires a text, speech, or writing system susceptible to linguistic analysis.
- It also requires enough exposure to the material to compare structure and usage.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Incomplete, eroded, or poorly transmitted text	-1
Rare, archaic, or very distant language	-2
Technical or heavily specialized register	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated with more context, comparable samples, or working time. Without new data, the same passage rarely opens through repetition alone.

Brief Example

A character tries to read an ancient inscription without a dictionary or local reference. The roll decides whether they can open the language enough to use the information.

THAUMATURGY

Thaumaturgy covers formally understanding thauma, its laws, manifestations, and interaction systems. It is used when the central question is understanding a thaumatic presence or phenomenon through study, not instinctive attunement.

It is distinct from Resonance. Resonance makes contact; Thaumaturgy understands. It also stays separate from Theology, which interprets systems of faith rather than thauma as a formal discipline.

Mechanical Profile

- Thaumaturgy functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Rarity of the phenomenon, instability of the thauma, environmental interference, and depth of analysis adjust that value.

- It requires a manifestation, trace, or problem of thaumatic nature.
- It also requires enough access to observe its behavior or structure.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Unstable, hostile, or partially veiled manifestation	-2
Weak trace or heavily contaminated field	-1
Immediate pressure preventing adequate observation	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated if the manifestation changes, stabilizes, or new evidence appears. Repeating it over the same unchanged phenomenon rarely improves the reading.

Brief Example

A character tries to understand why a thaumatic manifestation is warping local space before it becomes uncontrollable. The roll decides whether they read its logic.

HISTORY

History covers formally knowing past events, periods, peoples, and historical developments. It is used when the central question is whether a precedent from the past helps explain the present.

It is distinct from Archaeology. History reads the past through chronicles, records, and organized tradition; Archaeology reads it through physical remains. It also stays separate from Theology, though religious processes may form part of history.

Mechanical Profile

- History functions mostly as an **active** action in narrative scenes.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Antiquity, obscurity of the period, specificity of the reference, and access to context adjust that value.

- It requires a question whose answer depends on historical precedent or formal chronology.
- It also requires minimum data linking the case to a known period, people, or event.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Obscure, poorly documented, or regionally marginal period	-2
Partial reference or symbol without enough context	-1
Information mixed with doubtful tradition	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated with new references, context, or sources. Without additional evidence, the same question rarely changes through insistence.

Brief Example

A character tries to recall which old conflict explains the hostility between two present factions. The roll decides whether they recover the correct precedent.

GEOGRAPHY

Geography covers formally understanding regions, terrain, places, and their broader structure. It is used when the central question is applying knowledge of the world as organized space, not orienting through immediate field conditions.

It is distinct from Navigation. Geography knows the world; Navigation crosses it in real time. It also stays separate from Survival, which decides how to operate within hostile terrain.

Mechanical Profile

- Geography functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Remoteness of the region, rarity of the territory, precision required, and scale of the analysis adjust that value.

- It requires a question tied to regions, territories, or large-scale spatial arrangement.
- It also requires enough reference to connect the problem to cartographic or regional knowledge.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Remote, poorly documented, or shifting region	-2
Incomplete or vague spatial reference	-1
Need for high strategic precision	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated with maps, references, or additional context. Without new references, the same difficult question rarely improves.

Brief Example

A character tries to determine which territory controls a mountain pass and what strategic implications it has for the journey. The roll decides whether their mental map is enough.

ASTRONOMY

Astronomy covers formally understanding celestial bodies, astronomical cycles, and the logic of the sky. It is used when the central question is extracting reliable information from the disposition of the stars.

It is distinct from Theology. Astronomy treats the sky as a system; Theology treats doctrinal readings of the sacred. It also stays separate from Navigation, though it may support it when travel depends on the sky.

Mechanical Profile

- Astronomy functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Sky coverage, atmospheric clarity, complexity of the calculation, and rarity of the phenomenon adjust that value.

- It requires enough visibility of the sky or a relevant astronomical record.
- It also requires time or minimum reference for comparing cycles or positions.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Cloud cover, light interference, or partial view of the sky	-2
Rare phenomenon or especially precise calculation	-2
Incomplete temporal reference	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated if visibility changes, time passes, or new references appear. Without new celestial data, insisting rarely improves the reading.

Brief Example

A character tries to fix the date, orientation, or proximity of a celestial event from the visible sky. The roll decides whether they obtain a reliable reading.

THEOLOGY

Theology covers formally understanding gods, doctrine, sacred systems, and structures of faith. It is used when the central question is how a religious tradition functions as a body of knowledge.

It is distinct from Thaumaturgy. Thaumaturgy studies *tauma*; Theology studies how a faith interprets, organizes, or ritualizes it. It also stays separate from Resonance or Instinct, which are aura responses rather than doctrinal knowledge.

Mechanical Profile

- Theology functions mostly as an **active** action in narrative scenes.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Obscurity of the doctrine, syncretism, religious secrecy, and depth of the rite adjust that value.

- It requires a religious system, rite, symbol, or hierarchy susceptible to doctrinal analysis.
- It also requires enough context to connect it with known tradition or structure of faith.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Rare, secret, or heretical cult	-2
Symbol or rite out of context	-1
Fragmentary or deliberately ambiguous doctrine	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated with better context, access to liturgy, or new references. Without more doctrinal framework, repeating it rarely opens real understanding.

Brief Example

A character tries to understand what a rite found in a strange sanctuary demands and what authority it represents. The roll decides whether the doctrine is legible to them.

CRYPTOLOGY

Cryptology covers deciphering and analyzing systems of code, cipher, and intentionally hidden language. It is used when the central question is opening a message that was designed not to be understood.

It is distinct from Linguistics. Linguistics understands languages; Cryptology breaks deliberate concealment. It also stays separate from Interpretation, which enters after the message has already been opened.

Mechanical Profile

- Cryptology functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Strength of the cipher, length of the sample, redundancy available, and time pressure adjust that value.

- It requires a message, pattern, or system intentionally hidden.
- It also requires enough material to detect regularity, key, or structure.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Short or highly fragmentary sample	-1
Complex, multilayered, or low-redundancy cipher	-2
Need for rapid opening under pressure	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated if more text appears, a clue to the key emerges, or an additional pattern becomes visible. Without a new sample, insisting against the same lock rarely changes the result.

Brief Example

A character tries to open an intercepted message before its tactical value expires. The roll decides whether they break the system in time.

ARCHAEOLOGY

Archaeology covers reading and interpreting physical remains of the past, ruins, and ancient material culture. It is used when the central question is what a material remnant reveals about those who produced or used it.

It is distinct from History. History knows events; Archaeology reads physical traces. It also stays separate from Mining or Architecture, though it may rely on both when a site demands it.

Mechanical Profile

- Archaeology functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. State of preservation, stratigraphic mixing, cultural rarity, and access to the site adjust that value.

- It requires physical remains, ruins, or material culture susceptible to contextual reading.
- It also requires enough time or access to observe arrangement, layers, or manufacture.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Heavily degraded or disturbed ruin	-1
Confused or looted stratigraphic context	-2
Partial access to the site or piece	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated with new layers, objects, or better access to the site. Without widening the sample, repeating the same reading rarely produces more.

Brief Example

A character tries to determine which culture a ruin belongs to and what happened there without documentary support. The roll decides whether they can read the material past.

ARCHITECTURE

Architecture covers formally understanding the logic of built spaces, structures, and constructed environments. It is used when the central question is how a building or complex was conceived, arranged, or concealed.

It is distinct from Engineering. Engineering understands mechanisms and functional systems; Architecture reads built space as inhabitable form. It also stays separate from Archaeology, which uses those spaces as remains of the past.

Mechanical Profile

- Architecture functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Complexity of the building, later alterations, visibility of the floor plan, and rarity of the style adjust that value.

- It requires a built space or plan whose logic of arrangement can be read.
- It also requires enough access to the form, proportions, or continuity of the place.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Altered, incomplete, or partially collapsed building	-1
Very partial access to the structure or plan	-2
Rare or strongly hybrid architectural school	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated if more areas are explored, a plan appears, or visibility of the whole improves. Without new spatial information, insisting usually adds little.

Brief Example

A character tries to detect whether a structure hides unseen spaces or a concealed circulation logic. The roll decides whether they read the design's intent.

BELICOLOGY

Belicology covers formally understanding war, conflict systems, military doctrine, and the organization of combat. It is used when the central question is how to read a military situation as a system rather than as an immediate fight.

It is distinct from Leadership. Leadership commands in real time; Belicology understands doctrine, deployment, and the structure of war. It also stays separate from weapon competencies or direct tactical improvisation.

Mechanical Profile

- Belicology functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Scale of the conflict, clarity of deployment, rarity of doctrine, and pressure of the moment adjust that value.

- It requires a military situation, doctrine, or deployment susceptible to formal analysis.
- It also requires enough information to compare the scene with known conflict patterns.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Fragmentary information about forces or positions	-1
Rare, deceptive, or unconventional doctrine	-2
Situation too volatile for a complete reading	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

It may be reevaluated if the deployment becomes clearer, new forces appear, or the situation changes. Without new tactical information, repeating the same analysis rarely improves it.

Brief Example

A character tries to anticipate how an enemy force will reorder itself before the maneuver is complete. The roll decides whether the doctrine is legible in time.

COMPOSURE

Composure specializations express practiced inner regulation. They do not revolve around the body or direct social influence, but around the ability to sustain clarity, not break inwardly, restore oneself, and control what pressure lets others see.

Specializations in this block: Focus, Containment, Meditation, Poise

FOCUS

Focus covers the ability to keep attention fixed on a task, target, or line of thought when the environment is trying to scatter it. It is used when the central question is not whether the character breaks emotionally, but whether they manage to stay concentrated on what they are doing.

It is distinct from Containment. Containment resists inner collapse; Focus sustains directed attention. It also stays separate from Meditation, which restores and quiets rather than fixing the mind on a concrete target.

Mechanical Profile

- Focus functions mostly as an **active** action.

- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may become an **opposed test** if another creature actively tries to break the character's concentration.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Noise, urgency, task complexity, and active interference adjust that value.

- It requires a concrete task, target, or mental thread that must be sustained.
- It also requires enough pressure, distraction, or threat for maintaining attention to become a real problem.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Persistent noise, stimulus, or interruption	-1
Immediate threat or ongoing damage	-2
Long or cognitively dense task	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Focus may be evaluated again while the task remains open and concentration still has a functional target. Failure leaves carryover: attention that has already been broken or degraded does not return cleanly just because the roll is repeated.

Brief Example

A character tries to complete a delicate manipulation while combat keeps exploding around them. The roll defines whether they can sustain attention long enough to finish.

CONTAINMENT

Containment covers preventing emotional or mental collapse from interrupting the ability to act. It is used when pressure threatens to break the character inwardly: panic, horror, volitional collapse, or loss of inner control.

It is distinct from Tolerance. Tolerance resists physiological punishment; Containment resists mental or emotional break. If the main question is whether the mind breaks, yields to panic, or loses the ability to act, Containment is the right specialization.

Mechanical Profile

- Containment functions mostly as a **reactive** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may interact with an already defined opposition when the source of collapse comes from a specific hostile mental effect.

When there is no other defined opposition, the environmental or scene condition establishes the base threshold. The intensity of the shock, the nearness of the horror, and the accumulation of mental pressure adjust that value.

- It requires a real threat of panic, emotional break, or loss of inner control.
- It also requires that the character still be trying to preserve function under that pressure.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Sudden exposure to extreme horror or shock	-2
Accumulated emotional pressure without relief	-1
Isolation, helplessness, or a sense of entrapment	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Containment is evaluated again when a new wave of panic, horror, or volitional pressure rises. The previous failure continues to matter while the character remains on the edge of inner collapse.

Brief Example

A character witnesses something unbearable and still has to keep acting before the scene falls apart. The roll decides whether they manage not to break inwardly.

MEDITATION

Meditation covers deliberate restoration of the inner state: quieting internal noise, returning to center, and recovering clarity before continuing. It is used when the central action is not resisting an immediate emergency, but cultivating a functional pause that allows the interior to be recomposed.

It is distinct from Focus. Focus fixes attention on a task; Meditation quiets and restores. It also stays separate from Poise, which controls outward projection under pressure.

Mechanical Profile

- Meditation functions mostly as an **active** action in exploration or narrative pause.
- It is resolved against a **threshold**, not as an opposed test.
- It does not normally apply as a combat action.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Noise, insecurity of the place, outside urgency, and the magnitude of the inner burden adjust that value.

- It requires a minimal pause, space, or functional window in which the practice can happen.
- It also requires deliberate willingness to center, quiet, or restore the inner state.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Unsafe, exposed, or unstable place	-2
Frequent interruption or time pressure	-2
Severe accumulated psychological burden	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Meditation may be repeated if the character regains a new real window of calm or practice. A failed attempt does not produce full restoration and cannot simply be redone in the same instant without a change in circumstances.

Brief Example

A character tries to recover clarity before entering a chamber that demands precise reading and a steady head. The roll decides whether they manage to recompose themselves enough.

POISE

Poise covers maintaining outward composure and visible bearing under pressure. It is used when the central question is not whether the character breaks inwardly, but whether others can read that break, their fear, or their pain.

It is distinct from Containment. Containment is the inner work of not breaking; Poise is the outward projection that one has not broken. It also stays separate from Deception: Poise does not fabricate a lie, it only controls what leaks outward.

Mechanical Profile

- Poise functions mostly as a **reactive** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may become an **opposed test** if another creature deliberately tries to read, crack, or expose the character's composure.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. The intensity of scrutiny, the severity of the pressure, and the social importance of the moment adjust that value.

- It requires observers, social reading, or pressure that makes inner tension visible.
- It also requires that the character still be trying to preserve a functional facade.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Pain or fear made evident in the body	-2
Close scrutiny or a hostile audience	-2
Surprise, devastating news, or sudden loss of position	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Poise may be reevaluated when visible pressure changes or the scene again demands that the facade be sustained. Failure leaves visible leaks that do not disappear just because the roll is immediately repeated.

Brief Example

A character receives devastating news in the middle of a negotiation and needs no one to see the impact. The roll determines whether they keep their bearing or whether the crack becomes readable.

AURA

Aura specializations express essential response, attunement, and connection. They do not depend on formal analysis or conventional social influence, but on how the character's nature enters into contact with forces, beings, and bonds that are felt before they are explained.

Specializations in this block: Instinct, Resonance, Bond, Taming

INSTINCT

Instinct covers the character's primary response to something that has not yet been rationally processed. It is used when the central question is not what the character deduces, but what they feel, recognize, or reject from deep within before they can explain it.

It is distinct from Intuition. Intuition is adaptive inference; Instinct is essential response before analysis. It also stays separate from Perception, because Instinct does not depend on detecting a clear sensory detail.

Mechanical Profile

- Instinct functions mostly as a **reactive** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It is not usually a direct opposed test.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. The strangeness of the presence, the nearness of the danger, and the intensity of the essential prompting adjust that value.

- It requires something capable of addressing the character's deeper nature.
- It also requires a situation that calls for response before analysis or formal perception.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Sensory saturation or contradictory signals	-1
Intense exotric or extranatural interference	-2
Exhaustion or disconnection from one's own center	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Instinct is reevaluated when the presence changes, a new threat arises, or the character enters a different state of exposure. It is not forced as a chain of clean attempts against the same signal.

Brief Example

A character feels immediate rejection on entering a room that still seems empty to the rest of the group. The roll decides whether that reaction becomes useful reading before it is too late.

RESONANCE

Resonance covers active contact between the aura and something external: a force, a place, a presence, or an essential state. It is used when the central question is not what the character knows about it, but whether they can attune to it, feel it, or establish meaningful contact.

It is distinct from Thaumaturgy. Thaumaturgy studies tauma formally; Resonance feels and contacts it. It also stays separate from Instinct, which is involuntary and primary, whereas Resonance is active and directed.

Mechanical Profile

- Resonance functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may become an **opposed test** if another force or entity actively resists the contact.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Distance, essential noise, signal intensity, and affinity or dissonance adjust that value.

- It requires a presence, force, place, or state the aura can attempt to attune to.
- It also requires deliberate intent to enter contact through the aura.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Interference from multiple presences at once	-2
Weak, distant, or partially veiled signal	-1
Place saturated by incompatible forces	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Resonance may be reevaluated when the signal, distance, or the character's disposition changes. Failure does not mean the presence is not there, only that contact was not achieved in that state.

Brief Example

A character tries to read the essential charge of a sanctuary before crossing its threshold. The roll decides whether they attune to what the place emits or perceive only confused interference.

BOND

Bond covers a sustained essential connection with a specific being. It is used when the central question is not whether the character detects a momentary presence, but whether they can operate through, deepen, or rely on a bond that already carries real weight.

It is distinct from Resonance. Resonance is momentary contact; Bond is sustained connection. It also stays separate from Taming, which concerns practical handling of instinctive creatures rather than deep essential linkage.

Mechanical Profile

- Bond functions mostly as an **active** action in exploration or narrative play.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It only rarely becomes an **opposed test**, for example if something is actively trying to sever, muddy, or falsify the connection.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Distance, tension of the moment, the bonded being's state, and the connection's stability adjust that value.

- It requires a specific being with whom a sustained essential connection exists or can be deepened.
- It also requires enough time, shared experience, or intensity for the bond to matter.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Extreme distance or a barrier between both	-1
Recent trauma, conflict, or fracture in the bond	-2
Essential interference or rival presence	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Bond may be reevaluated when the state of the bond changes or the fiction opens a new window for connection. Failure does not automatically break the bond, but it does mean it could not operate then.

Brief Example

A character needs to feel the state of a being with whom they share a deep connection while both are separated by danger and distance. The roll decides whether the bond reaches across that pressure.

TAMING

Taming covers the practical handling of instinctive creatures: calming them, guiding them, training them, or preventing them from breaking loose. It is used when the central question is not whether there is a deep essential bond, but whether the character can enter the response system of a non-rational creature and produce trust, calm, or direction.

It is distinct from Riding. Riding concerns technical control of a mount in motion. Taming concerns the creature as an instinctive being. It also stays separate from Bond, which implies sustained essential connection rather than merely functional handling.

Mechanical Profile

- Taming functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may become an **opposed test** when the creature actively resists handling in that instant.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. The creature's fear, agitation, pain, and the moment's pressure adjust that value.

- It requires an instinctive creature the character can interact with in a real way.
- It also requires enough contact, presence, or handling access to influence its response.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Creature wounded, terrified, or already overwhelmed	-2
Noisy, hostile, or stimulus-saturated environment	-1
No prior familiarity with the creature	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Taming may be reevaluated if the creature has not broken contact or escalated beyond recovery. Failure may worsen its state and close immediate future opportunities.

Brief Example

A character tries to calm an agitated beast before it attacks or bolts. The roll determines whether they can enter its instinctive response before the situation breaks.

PRESENCE

Presence specializations express how much weight the character carries in the perception of others and in the scene itself. They do not stop at speaking or commanding; they also include the ability to enter a space without being fixed by someone else's attention.

Specializations in this block: Leadership, Negotiation, Intimidation, Imitation, Stealth

LEADERSHIP

Leadership covers directing others through authority, structure, and force of command. It is used when the central question is not whether the character frightens, persuades, or bargains, but whether they can get several people to act under a recognized direction.

It is distinct from Intimidation. Intimidation bends through fear; Leadership organizes voluntary followership. It also stays separate from War Studies, which knows war as a system rather than exercising command in real time.

Mechanical Profile

- Leadership functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may become an **opposed test** if another will is actively competing for command in that instant.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. Urgency, group fragmentation, collective fear, and clarity of command chain adjust that value.

- It requires a group, formation, or set of allies over whom real authority can be exercised.
- It also requires a clear intention to coordinate, order, or maintain cohesion under pressure.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Disorganized, divided, or low-trust group	-2
Immediate pressure, panic, or extreme tactical noise	-2
Ambiguous or disputed authority	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Leadership may be reevaluated when the group's situation changes or a new window for command appears. Failure may leave fracture or doubt that does not vanish just because the order is repeated.

Brief Example

A character tries to re-center their allies when the formation is already starting to break. The roll decides whether they can pull the group back together before chaos becomes irreversible.

NEGOTIATION

Negotiation covers producing agreements through exchange, leverage, and controlled social balance. It is used when the central question is not whether the character imposes fear or lies, but whether they can structure a deal the other side will accept.

It is distinct from Intimidation. Intimidation seeks submission; Negotiation seeks agreement. It also stays separate from Deception, because Negotiation works in the space of real exchange, not fabricated narrative.

Mechanical Profile

- Negotiation functions mostly as an **active** action in narrative scenes.
- It is normally resolved as an **opposed test** against the other side's position or will.
- It may be resolved against a **threshold** if the other side is not actively negotiating but the framework of the agreement still presents real difficulty.

When there is no defined active opposition, the environmental or scene condition establishes the base threshold. Power asymmetry, urgency, what each side risks, and the quality of leverage adjust that value.

- It requires a counterpart at least minimally willing to enter exchange.
- It also requires something to offer, demand, or structure as part of the agreement.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Weak or exposed bargaining position	-2
Time limit or severe outside pressure	-1
Hostile, humiliated, or already distrustful counterpart	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Negotiation may be reevaluated if the terms, context, or real leverage change. Failure may harden the other side and close immediate identical attempts.

Brief Example

A character tries to turn an open confrontation into an advantageous arrangement before the other side closes every exit. The roll decides whether they can structure an acceptable deal.

INTIMIDATION

Intimidation covers imposing pressure through threat, force of presence, or projection of fear. It is used when the central question is not whether the character organizes others or persuades rationally, but whether they can make someone yield because they fear the consequences.

It is distinct from Leadership. Leadership produces voluntary followership; Intimidation produces submission through fear. It also stays separate from Deception, because Intimidation does not fabricate a false narrative: it makes a threat credible.

Mechanical Profile

- Intimidation functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved as an **opposed test** against the target's will or resistance.
- It may fall back to a **threshold** when there is no clear active opposition but there is still a coercive pressure scenario.

When there is no defined active opposition, the environmental or scene condition establishes the base threshold. Target vulnerability, immediacy of the threat, and apparent superiority adjust that value.

- It requires a creature capable of perceiving threat, force of presence, or consequence.
- It also requires a position, gesture, or circumstance that makes the pressure believable.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Unconvincing threat or weak position	-2
Desperate, fanatical, or nothing-left-to-lose target	-2
Pressure diluted by third parties or protective context	-1
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Intimidation may be reevaluated if the power relation or the credibility of the threat changes. Failure may temporarily harden the target against the same immediate pressure.

Brief Example

A character tries to break a guard's resistance before he calls for reinforcements. The roll determines whether the threat weighs more than his will to hold.

IMITATION

Imitation covers reproducing another person's behavior, voice, manners, or social patterns with enough conviction to pass as them or as a recognizable social type. It is used when the central question is not whether the character remains beneath notice, but whether they can seem like something else.

It is distinct from Stealth. Stealth aims to reduce how much attention the character attracts; Imitation aims to pass as someone else. It also stays separate from purely verbal deception, because here the center is behavioral and vocal reproduction.

Mechanical Profile

- Imitation functions mostly as an **active** action.
- It is normally resolved against a **threshold**.
- It may become an **opposed test** if someone knows the imitated model well and actively compares the behavior.

The scene condition sets the base threshold. The audience's familiarity with the model, the duration of exposure, and the role's demands adjust that value.

- It requires a behavioral pattern, voice, or identity that can be observed and reproduced.
- It also requires enough access to the social context for the imitation to have a chance to hold.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Incomplete knowledge of the model or social environment	-2
Close scrutiny or prolonged conversation	-1
Physical or vocal trait difficult to reproduce	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Imitation may be reevaluated if the audience, the context, or the degree of exposure changes. Failure before the same observer usually leaves suspicion and makes it harder to repeat the same identity immediately.

Brief Example

A character tries to cross a checkpoint by adopting the bearing and voice of someone who should be waved through. The roll decides whether the reproduction holds up under scrutiny.

STEALTH

Stealth covers the active reduction of how much others register the character: not only moving without noise, but modulating presence, rhythm, visibility, and outside attention so the character never becomes a relevant element of the scene. It is used when the central problem is not being registered by observers, surveillance, or active attention.

It is distinct from Imitation and Deception. Stealth does not aim to pass as someone else or sustain a spoken lie. Its core is reducing the attention others give to the character's presence.

Mechanical Profile

- The baseline use of Stealth is an **active** action.
- If a creature is actively observing, listening, or searching, it is resolved as an **opposed test**.
- If the difficulty comes only from the space, the light, the social flow, or the available cover, it is resolved against a **threshold**.

When there is no active search, the environmental or scene condition establishes the base threshold. Illumination, cover, background noise, the flow of people, and the character's exposure adjust it.

- It requires enough cover, shadow, traffic, noise, or timing to reduce registration.
- It also requires a route or position from which presence can be minimized in a credible way.

Common Penalties

SITUATION	PENALTY
Open light or backlighting	-2
Sparse cover	-1
Noisy surface or traffic that denies personal rhythm	-2
Focused attention or prepared surveillance	-2
Fatigue	-1 per Fatigue level

Retries

Failure does not automatically allow another attempt against the same observer and from the same position. It can only be retried if cover, outside attention, the flow of the place, or the route changes.

Brief Example

A character crosses a watched corridor without being fixed by the guards' attention while the flow of the place shifts around them. The roll decides whether they stay outside the focus.